



UPDATED NUMBERS

RS Chair accepts merger of 7 AAP MPs with BJP

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STOCK CONCERNS

No immediate need for petrol, diesel imports: govt.

BUSINESS » PAGE 11





'TRUST-BUILDING EXERCISE'

Ladakh groups seek talks during Shah's visit

NEWS » PAGE 8

DIGITAL OVERREACH

A tightening of the fist in digital public square

The draft amendments to IT Rules trigger fears

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RUNNING RIOT

RCB attack skittles out DC for a paltry 75

SPORT » PAGE 13

NEARBY

▼



Form scheme for rehabilitation of transpersons: HC

MADURAI
The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has directed the State government to formulate a comprehensive rehabilitation scheme for transpersons at the taluk level to enable sustainable livelihood. » PAGE 4

Prime accused in fireworks unit blast case held

VIRUDHUNAGAR
Eswari, the licensee of Vanaja Fireworks at Kattannarapatti near Virudhunagar, where 25 workers were killed in a blast on April 19, was arrested on Sunday and has been remanded in custody. » PAGE 4

India, New Zealand sign 'historic' free trade deal

Deal to be implemented after New Zealand Parliament ratification later this year; Prime Minister calls the agreement a milestone, says it reflects 'convergence of values, trust, and shared ambition'

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

India and New Zealand on Monday signed a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) that Prime Ministers of both the countries hailed as a "historic" step towards deepening trade, investment, and people-to-people ties.

The FTA, signed by Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal and his New Zealand counterpart, Todd McClay, in New Delhi, will see New Zealand removing tariffs on all goods imported from India, while India will remove or reduce tariffs on 95% of current imports from New Zealand.

"Today marks a historic milestone in India's journey towards deeper global engagement and shared prosperity," a statement

Deal dynamics

Immediate elimination

- Wood | ■ Wool
- Leather-raw hides

Phased elimination

- Petroleum oil
- Vegetable oils
- Select electrical machinery

Tariff reductions

- Wine and pharma
- Polymers, aluminium, iron and steel articles

The graphic lists select products on which India will be reducing or eliminating tariffs, as well as items excluded from the deal. New Zealand has removed tariffs on all items

Products excluded by India

- Dairy products (milk, cream, whey, yoghurt, cheese etc.)

- Animal products (other than sheep meat)
- Agricultural products (onions, chana, peas, corn, almonds etc.)
- Sugar | ■ Artificial honey
- Copper and articles thereof (cathodes, cartridges, rods)
- Aluminium and articles thereof (ingots, billets etc.)



Sealing the deal: Union Minister of Commerce and Industry, Piyush Goyal, with New Zealand's Minister for Trade and Investment, Todd McClay, during the signing ceremony of the FTA in New Delhi on Monday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

read out by Mr. Goyal quoted Prime Minister Narendra Modi as saying. "The signing of the India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement reflects our strengthening economic partnership and a convergence of values, trust and shared

ambition between two vibrant democracies." This FTA, discussions for which were announced in March 2025 and concluded in December 2025, is one of the fastest India has negotiated. The deal still needs to be

ratified by New Zealand's Parliament, which Mr. McClay said would happen soon while adding that it would come into force within this year.

CONTINUED ON
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Iran offers to reopen Strait of Hormuz if U.S. lifts its blockade

Associated Press
CAIRO

Iran has offered to end its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz if the U.S. lifts its blockade on the country and ends the war in a proposal that would postpone discussions on the Islamic Republic's nuclear programme, two regional officials said on Monday.

U.S. President Donald Trump seems unlikely to accept the offer, which was passed to the Americans by Pakistan and would leave unresolved the disagreements that led the U.S. and Israel to go to war on February 28. Mr. Trump has said one of the major reasons he went to war was to deny Iran the ability to develop nuclear weapons.

The offer emerged as Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi visited Russia and met President Vladimir Putin, who, according



Russian President Vladimir Putin with Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi in St. Petersburg on Monday. AFP

to state news agency Tass, praised Iranian people as "bravely and heroically fighting for their sovereignty". Russia would do everything possible to bring peace to West Asia, Tass reported Mr. Putin as saying. It is unclear what, if any, assistance Moscow, which has long been a key backer of Tehran, might offer now.

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HEZBOLLAH REJECTS TALKS
» PAGE 12

T.N. grows by double digits for second straight year

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu has, for the second consecutive year, recorded double-digit real economic growth. The State has posted a growth rate of 10.83% for 2025-26. During 2024-25, the figure was 11.19%. The figure for 2025-26 could be the highest for any State, even though the Union Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation has not yet released the data for 11 States, including Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, and Kerala, besides four Union Territories.

Above national average
The State's performance in terms of the growth rate "significantly surpasses" the national average growth rate of 7.4% (base year: 2011-12).

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 4

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Statement of Audited Financial Results for the Quarter and Financial Year Ended March 31, 2026

TMB

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Particulars	Quarter Ended 31 st Mar 2026	Quarter Ended 31 st Mar 2025	Change / Growth %
TOTAL DEPOSITS	61,712	53,689	14.94
TOTAL ADVANCES	53,379	44,366	20.32
CASA	17,365	14,193	22.35
OPERATING PROFIT	522.31	404.00	29.28
NET PROFIT	373.65	291.90	28.01
NET INTEREST INCOME	704.45	567.92	24.04
SMA %	1.29	2.55	126 bps
GROSS NPA %	0.73	1.25	52 bps
NET NPA %	0.18	0.36	18 bps
ROA %	2.05	1.81	24 bps
ROE %	15.03	13.79	124 bps
CRAR %	33.73	32.71	102 bps
EPS (₹) (Not Annualised)	23.60	18.44	27.98

Sl. No.	Particulars	Quarter Ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Quarter Ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)	Year Ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Year Ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)
1.	Total Income from Operations (net)	1,792.16	1,542.06	6,696.49	6,141.75
2.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before Tax, Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	503.52	386.78	1,806.60	1,574.89
3.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before Tax, (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	503.52	386.78	1,806.60	1,574.89
4.	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after Tax, (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	373.65	291.90	1,337.55	1,182.61
5.	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit/(Loss) for the period (after tax) and other comprehensive Income (after tax)	NA	NA	NA	NA
6.	Paid up Equity Share Capital	158.35	158.35	158.35	158.35
7.	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserves)	9,951.81	8,850.34	9,951.81	8,850.34
8.	Securities Premium Account	769.23	769.23	769.23	769.23
9.	Networth	10,110.16	9,008.69	10,110.16	9,008.69
10.	Paid up Debt Capital / Outstanding Debt	-	-	-	-
11.	Debt Equity Ratio	0.02	-	0.02	-
12.	Earnings Per Share (of Rs.10/- each) (Not Annualised) (for continuing and discontinued operations)				
a)	Basic:	23.60	18.44	84.47	74.68
b)	Diluted:	23.60	18.44	84.47	74.68
13.	Capital Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-
14.	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-

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NOTE: 1. The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly / Annual Financial Results filed with Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Quarterly/ Annual Financial Results is available on the website of the Stock Exchange(s) (www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com) and on the Bank's Website (www.tmb.bank.in). 2. Information relating to Total comprehensive income and other comprehensive income is not furnished as Ind-AS is not yet made applicable to banks. 3. Previous period figures have been regrouped and reclassified, where necessary to make them comparable with current period figures | Place: Thoothukudi | Date: 27.04.2026

Toll-free: 180 0425 0426 | www.tmb.bank.in

Tamilnad Mercantile Bank Ltd., Regd. Office: 57, V.E. Road, Thoothukudi, Tamilnadu - 628 002.

CM YK

A CH-CE

INBRIEF



Tamparam Commissioner inspects counting centre

Commissioner of Police for Tamparam City Sanjay Kumar on Monday inspected the strong rooms and counting centre at MIT, Chromepet. During his visit, he reviewed the deployment of police personnel across all security layers, verified CCTV surveillance systems, and directed officers to maintain strict vigilance, and adhere to Election Commission protocols. All electronic voting machines (EVMs), voter verifiable paper audit trails (VVPATs), and related materials were transported under armed escort to designated counting centres. The police said, as per Election Commission guidelines, strong rooms housing EVMs have been placed under round-the-clock CCTV surveillance, and are secured with three-tier security system.

Landlord's son arrested for sexually harassing tenant

The MGR Nagar Police arrested a 41-year-old man for sexually harassing a woman. According to the police, a 27-year-old woman residing in T. Nagar, was living with her elder sister and was employed at a private firm. On Saturday night, her sister had gone out to visit a relative, and the woman was sleeping at home without bolting the door from inside. At that time, Anand Krishnan, the landlord's son, allegedly trespassed into the house, sexually harassed her, and left after issuing death threats. Based on the complaint lodged by the victim, a case was registered against Anand Krishnan under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and the police arrested him.

CMRL's Koyambedu-Chennai Trade Centre stretch delayed, likely to be launched in Aug.

There is a shortage of manpower to build the stations as hundreds of workers have gone to vote in the Assembly polls in West Bengal; sources say that it is difficult to meet even the August deadline

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

In yet another disappointment for Chennai Metro Rail commuters, the phase II stretch from Koyambedu to Chennai Trade Centre, which was slated for opening in June this year, has suffered delays and is likely to be launched only in August.

Extending for a total of 118.9-km, the ₹63,246-crore phase II project will touch various corners of the city with three corridors—Madhavaram to SIP-COT (corridor 3), Poonamallee to Light House (corridor 4), and Madhavaram to Sholinganallur (corridor 5).

The Koyambedu-Chennai Trade Centre stretch, part of corridor 5, was next in line for inauguration, after the Poonamallee-Porur-Vadapalani corridor, part of corridor 4, which had to be opened in December but is now scheduled to be launched post elections.

The 11.5-km Koyambedu-Chennai Trade Centre stretch is a fully elevated corridor and when train operations begin, there



Slow progress: While 500 workers are engaged now, CMRL needs at least 300 workers more to complete the stretch. M. SRINATH

will be a stop at the following locations – Koyambedu, Koyambedu Market, Natesan Nagar, Virugambakkam, Alwarthirunagar, Valasaravakkam, Karambakkam, Alapakkam, Mugavivakkam, Ramapuram, Manapakkam, and Chennai Trade Centre.

The opening of this stretch will benefit commuters residing in these localities not only because a mass rapid transit connectivity becomes available, but also because at Koyambedu – where phase I and phase II networks meet – they can switch trains and commute in the phase I network. For instance, if someone from Virugambakkam wants to head to

Chennai Central or Anna Salai or Tiruvottiyur, then they can change from the phase II to phase I network at Koyambedu station.

According to officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL), the viaduct work is nearing completion and of the 24 km track to be laid, 7.5 km has been completed so far. As in the case of the delay in building stations between Porur and Vadapalani in corridor 4, in the Koyambedu-Chennai Trade Centre stretch too, they have been grappling with shortage of workers.

With hundreds of workers gone for voting in the West Bengal Assembly elections, CMRL has been

scrambling to divert the existing workers to this stretch to improve the progress. While 500 workers are engaged now, CMRL needs at least 300 more workers to complete the stretch.

Shifting sewer lines

“Another major challenge we faced in construction of this stretch is shifting of the utilities at Kaliyammann Koil Street in Virugambakkam. The old sewer network which was in the centre of the road had to be moved to either side of the road which took almost a year and a half,” an official said.

The sewer lines were very old and since CMRL was moving them, they also had to replace them with enhanced capacity with a few new pumping stations. The 300 mm pipelines had to be upgraded with 600 mm or sometimes 800 mm pipelines.

Though CMRL said the work can be finished by August, sources said, it is going to be extremely difficult to even meet this deadline. Even if the viaduct and track work is finished, there is enormous work left to be completed to build the stations and their entry/exit points, sources said.



Pollution concern: An inlet through which untreated sewage and plastic waste flow into Pallikaranai marshland.

Untreated sewage flows into marshland

R. Aishwaryaa
CHENNAI

Untreated sewage and domestic garbage continue to be discharged into the Pallikaranai marshland from adjacent residential neighbourhoods.

Vidyasagar Jagadeesan, a Chennai-based activist, claimed that he recently observed sewage inflows at two locations close to the marshland limits during a visit to the park close by. “Untreated sewage and plastic waste are being let out into the Pallikaranai freshwater marshland,” he said. He added that the civic authorities must investigate those responsible for the contamination and take action.

One inlet was identified on the opposite side of the marshland, from the Mahalakshmi Nagar and Balaji Nagar areas, he said.

He added that thick clusters of invasive water hyacinth were choking the top surface of the water body beneath utility pipelines. The stagnant, dark water is polluted with discarded plastic water bottles, polythene materials,

and household waste accumulating heavily near concrete drainage culverts.

“A second discharge point was located at the Kaivelu junction, carrying sewage from Velachery and AGS Colony into the waterbody. The discharge is visible near the two bridges situated inside the park’s designated walking area. The water contamination at both junctions is severe,” he said.

Over a year after the Greater Chennai Corporation stated that untreated leachate discharge into the wetland from the Perungudi dumpyard would be addressed, the proposals are yet to be implemented. In April 2025, the civic body had assured that it would engage experts from Anna University to mitigate the contamination. However, this plan is yet to take shape.

The civic body is planning a ₹11.17-crore windrow composting facility to process 50 tonnes of garden waste and tender coconut shells everyday, alongside a similar facility specifically for Perungudi at an estimated cost of ₹15 crore.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 28, Tuesday), the following articles are available:

■ Legal limits on U.S. war involvement
[newsth.live/EPf70j](#)

■ Enhanced CAR-T therapy clears solid tumours by finding ‘faint’ targets
[newsth.live/carttherapy](#)

You can use your smartphone’s inbuilt features to access these articles. If it’s an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it’s an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Man beaten to death by co-passenger on moving bus

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police have arrested a 25-year-old man for beating an elderly man to death on a bus, after a dispute over route details.

The victim, Chandrasekaran, 74, boarded an MTC bus, heading from Guduvanchery to Va-

dapalani. The accused, Amarnath, who had already boarded the bus at Tambaram, asked the conductor whether the bus would go to Koyambedu. The conductor said it would go only up to Vadapalani. The youth then directed at the LED display showing route details and asked Chandrasekaran what was writ-

ten on it. The elderly man told he did not know and asked him to check with the conductor.

This led to an argument between the two, and the conductor intervened and asked Chandrasekaran to move to another seat. As he got up to move to another seat, Amarnath allegedly grabbed him by the neck

and repeatedly punched him on the face and chest. Chandrasekaran collapsed on the spot and was rushed to the government hospital in Chromepet, where doctors declared him dead.

Fellow passengers apprehended Amarnath and handed him over to the Chromepet police, who arrested him.

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Centre for Railway Information Systems
Channayyapuri, New Delhi-110021
TENDER NOTICE
Tender No: 2026_CRIS_ELECT_01 dt. 28/04/2026. **Subject:** Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract (AMC) of Variable Refrigerant Flow (VRF) systems of different makes installed in CRIS Office at DMRC Building, Supreme Court Metro Station New Delhi-110001. **Tender Closing Date:** 19/05/2026 (15:00 hrs.). Tender Documents can be downloaded from Website [www.ireps.gov.in](#). For future modification/extensions please see [www.ireps.gov.in](#).

CORRIGENDUM FOR TENDER NOTICE NO.: CON/2026/FEB/03 DATED: 28-02-2026
Corrigendum No. 04 for Tender Notice No. CON/2026/FEB/03, dated: 28-02-2026 against Tender No. CE-CON/FT-EPC-2026-04 has been published. For details please visit in website [www.ireps.gov.in](#).
CE/Con/LMG Project, Maligaon
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CONSTRUCTION OF BALANCE WORK
E-Tender Notice No. CON/2026/APR/02 Dated: 20-04-2026. Open tender through e-Tendering system is invited from experienced and reputed contractor(s)/firm(s) for the following works: **Tender No. CE/CON/DK/EPC/2026/02. Name of work:** Construction of Balance Work of Single Line BG Tunnel No. 6 Main Tunnel (Length-1746 m), Escape Tunnel (Length-1542 m) and Cut and Cover (Length-250 m) and Slope protection work from Portal P1 side and other ancillary Works between Ch. 45750.0 m to Ch. 50746.0 m in Pherima-Pipema Section in Connection with Dimapur-Kohima New BG Line Project. **Approx. value:** ₹506,18,35,956.57/- **Earnest Money:** ₹10,12,36,800/- **Date & Time of closing of tender:** 14.30 hrs. on 29-05-2026 **& opening at:** 15.30 hrs. on 04-06-2026. The complete information and tender document of above e-Tender will be available at [www.ireps.gov.in](#)
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IREPS
Centre for Railway Information Systems
Channayyapuri, New Delhi-110021
Notice for E-Auction of Digi-Rail-Chemist
Centre for Railway Information Systems (CRIS) is conducting an e-auction on 14.05.2026 under the Digi-Rail-Chemist project for supply and delivery of medicines to Northern Railway Central Hospital (NRCH) including Health Units, Dispensaries under its administrative control, and / or their Railway-beneficiaries (under UMID) for the areas covered in the e-Auction Catalogue. Interested and eligible vendors are required to register on the Indian Railways E-Procurement System (IREPS) portal ([https://www.ireps.gov.in](#)). A one-time non-refundable registration fee (as applicable) of ₹10,000/- + GST is to be paid online prior to participation in the e-auction, if not already paid. Auction details are available on the IREPS E-Auction Leasing Module under Organization CRIS. E-auction Catalogue No. 0126 MED1. Auction Start on 14.05.2026 at 11:00 hours. In this regard, a vendor familiarization meeting on IREPS e-Auction Leasing portal is being organized at CRIS Conference Hall, 3rd Floor, TPI Building, 4-A, Ring Road, I.P. Estate, New Delhi on 04.05.2026 at 11:00 Hrs. Interested vendors may attend.

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SOUTHERN RAILWAY
Central Workshops :: Golden Rod ::
Southern Railway :: Tiruchirappalli 620 004
Extra Division :: E-Tender Notice
No. CWC192VBPOWDERCOATING dated: 24.04.2026
“Powder coating of foldable snack tables, bottle holders and grab handles of Vande Bharat coaches including stripping and fitment of components”

1. Value	Rs.17,71,926.00 inclusive of GST@18%
2. Bid Security Amount	Rs.35,400.00
3. Contract period	15 months
4. Tender Closing Date & Time	18.05.2026 @ 12:00 hours

Assistant Works Manager/Carriage for Chief Workshop Manager/GOC

S. E. RAILWAY – TENDER
For and on behalf of the President of India, the Chief Engineer (CON)/S, South Eastern Railway, Garden Reach, Kolkata-700043 invites E-tender for the following work. Following tender has been uploaded on website [www.ireps.gov.in](#). The tender will be closed at 12.00 hrs. on due date. **E-Tender Notice No.: 4615-GRC-CE-C-SO-04-2026, Date: 24.04.2026, Brief Description of work:** Composite work for Development of infrastructure facilities for maintenance of HHP Electric Locomotives in ELKP Loco Shed, Kharagpur, South Eastern Railway and other allied miscellaneous works under jurisdiction of Dy. CE/Con/II/Kharagpur, South Eastern Railway. **Approx. Cost:** ₹ 72.42 Crore, **Bid Security:** ₹ 1,44,83,900, **Completion Period:** 24 months. **Closing Date:** 26.05.2026. Interested tenderers may visit website [www.ireps.gov.in](#) for full details/description/specification of the tenders and submit their bids online. In no case manual tender for this item will be accepted. **N.B.:** Prospective bidders may regularly visit [www.ireps.gov.in](#) to participate in all other tenders. (PR-89)

JAPIT
(An Autonomous body under Department of Information Technology, Govt. of Jharkhand)
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Phone: 0651-2401044/2401067, E-mail- [japit.doit@rediffmail.com](#)
Corrigendum for Cancellation
It is to inform that the Tender Ref.: JAP-IT/JHSECURE-1/2025 for “Procurement of Supply, Installation and Support for High End Server (02), End Point Protection Unit Rate (8,000 Users), Smart LED TV 65 Inch (02) for JAPIT, Ranchi, Jharkhand” has been cancelled and the same has also been published on Govt. official site at [Jharkhandtenders.gov.in](#)
PR Ref No. 348716
Sd/- (OSD, JAP-IT)
PR 378543 Information Technology(26-27)D

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
NATIONAL CENTRE FOR DISEASE CONTROL (DIRECTORATE GENERAL OF HEALTH SERVICES)
22- SHAM NATH MARG, DELHI - 110 054
PUBLIC NOTICE
Applications are invited for engagement of the 7 Non-Medical Scientists, for a period of one year or till regular officers join, whichever is earlier, at NCDC, Delhi and its branches, through Screening cum Selection Mode at NCDC, 22- Sham Nath Marg (Near Civil Lines Metro Station), Delhi- 110 054, as under:

Name of the post	No. of posts	Details of Vacancy	Place of Posting
Assistant Director (Entomology)	1	OBC	NCDC, Delhi
Deputy Assistant Director (Entomology)	3	UR, EWS-1, ST-1	NCDC, Delhi-2, NCDC, Patna-1
Deputy Assistant Director (Bio-Chemistry)	1	UR	NCDC, Delhi
Deputy Assistant Director (Microbiology)	1	OBC	NCDC, Delhi
Deputy Assistant Director (Veterinary)	1	UR	NCDC, Delhi

The last date of submission of application is 14.05.2026. The application must reach this office on or before 14.05.2026, by speed post/ by hand on all working days from 10.00 AM to 5.00 PM at General Services Section, Room No. 202, NCDC, 22 - Sham Nath Marg, Delhi - 110054. Application received after 14.05.2026 will not be entertained.

After scrutiny of the application forms, only eligible candidates as per ToR will be informed through email to appear for interview with date and time.

The Educational Qualification, ToR and other conditions may be viewed on the NCDC Website: [www.ncdc.mohfw.gov.in](#).

NOTE: The Competent Authority reserves the right to modify or cancel selection process (in part or full), if need so arises without issuing any further reasons whatsoever.

Assistant Director (Admin.)
Email: [prakashdoyal@ncdc.gov.in](#)
Phone No. 011-23971875

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PUBLIC NOTICE
NOTICE FOR DISPOSAL OF MEDICAL RECORDS
The public is hereby informed that Deepam Hospitals Limited proposes to permanently dispose of patient medical records (non-MLC cases) up to the year 2015. A copy of the concerned patient’s medical record will be issued upon a written request submitted along with valid government-issued identity proof, addressed to The Medical Records Officer (MRD), within 45 days from the date of this notice. The hospital authorities will not entertain any request thereafter, as all such records would have been permanently destroyed.
DEEPAH HOSPITALS GROUP
+91 97904 97905
[ask@deepamhospitals.com](#)

NOTICE FOR DISPOSAL OF MEDICAL RECORDS
The public is hereby informed that Deepam Pallavaram Hospital proposes to permanently dispose of patient medical records (non-MLC cases) up to the year 2015. A copy of the concerned patient’s medical record will be issued upon a written request submitted along with valid government-issued identity proof, addressed to The Medical Records Officer (MRD), within 45 days from the date of this notice. The hospital authorities will not entertain any request thereafter, as all such records would have been permanently destroyed.
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Westerly winds to increase temperatures in the city and other coastal areas from May

According to a senior meteorologist, the rise in temperature in coastal regions will be brought down by the daily onset of the sea breeze that will bring some respite from the heat for residents

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Temperatures in Chennai city and the rest of the coastal stations in the State could see a slight increase from May 1 when the Westerly winds start blowing from the hot Rayalaseema region.

Interior areas that are already witnessing above normal temperatures by 2-3 degrees Celsius could witness a further increase, the Regional Meteorological Centre (RMC), Chennai, said on Monday. Light to moderate rain have also been forecast till May 2 over isolated places across the State and this could bring down temperatures.

However, this rise in temperature in coastal regions will be brought down by the daily onset of the sea breeze that will bring some respite for the coastal areas, said senior meteorologist Y.E.A. Raj. “Every year, during April-end and the beginning of May, the surface winds will reverse from Easterlies to Westerlies leading to higher temperatures. From October, when the northeast monsoon sets, the State gets the Easterly winds that blow from the sea. Unhindered solar radiation and lack of summer clouding are two more reasons for the in-



Tough times: Interior areas could see a further rise in temperature, according to the RMC. R. RAGU

On Tuesday, light to moderate rain has been forecast at isolated places in districts in the Western Ghats

crease in heat over the interior regions. We have had very sparse rainfall in April so far due to lack of thunderstorm activity,” he said.

Mr. Raj also said that coastal stations such as Chennai Nungambakkam, Cuddalore, and Pamban have remained cooler than stations such as Vellore or Madurai or Tiruchi because of the Easterly Sea

breeze. “From next month, the time of onset of the sea breeze will be very important as from that point there will be a definite fall in temperature by three to four degrees Celsius and increase in humidity by about 20% to 30%. However, if there is an early onset of the Southwest monsoon as predicted by some models, the winds over Chennai and surroundings too will be the Southwesterlies and the temperature would be closer to the normal range,” he added.

On Tuesday, light to moderate rain has been forecast at isolated places over the Western Ghats dis-

tricts and coastal districts of Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, and Karaikal.

This is likely to be accompanied by thunder-showers and lightning at one or two places. On Wednesday, isolated places are likely to get light to moderate rain with some getting thundershowers.

On Thursday, isolated places in Nilgiris, Erode, Salem, Coimbatore, Dharmapuri, and Krishnagiri are likely to witness heavy rainfall.

Friday’s forecast shows that heavy rain is likely to occur at isolated places over Nilgiris, Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Dindigul, and Thenni districts.

After State, K.N. Nehru moves High Court against direction to register FIR in cash-for-jobs case

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In the latest development linked to the alleged cash-for-jobs scam in the Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department, Minister K.N. Nehru, too, has filed a review application, urging the Madras High Court to set aside its February 20, 2026 direction to the DVAC to register an FIR “forthwith”.

The Minister’s review application has been listed along with the State government’s review application before Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan on Tuesday.

In its grounds for review, the State had claimed that the February 20 order suffers from errors apparent on the face of the record. It also claimed that the order had legal infirmities, which were against the settled principles of law and the statutory provisions under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and the Prevention of

Corruption Act.

A Division Bench of former Chief Justice Manindra Mohan Shrivastava and Justice Murugan had ordered the registration of the FIR while allowing a writ petition filed by AIADMK Rajya Sabha member I.S. Inbadurai. The court had taken note of a 232-page dossier shared by the ED with the State police regarding the alleged scam.

Then, the judges agreed with ED Special Public Prosecutor N. Ramesh that the ED had shared solid materials to arrive at a prima facie conclusion of several crores of rupees having changed hands for filling 2,538 posts of Assistant Engineers, Junior Engineers, and Town Planning Officers in Mr. Nehru’s department.

The ED had laid its hands on the incriminating materials in April 2025 while conducting a search-and-seizure operation, in connection with a bank fraud case, on premises linked to the Minister’s

brother N. Ravichandran. The materials disclosed the receipt of bribes of ₹25 lakh to ₹35 lakh per person, and sharing of call letters with the candidates even before they were officially selected and appointed.

“The details shared and available materials reveal that those candidates got selected pursuant to the alleged transactions and when a large-scale corruption is stated to have happened involving several hundred crores of rupees, we find that the source material is sufficient enough disclosing the commission of a cognizable offence for the purpose of registering a case,” the Division Bench had said in its February 20 order.

However, the DVAC failed to register the FIR, prompting the AIADMK MP to file a contempt of court petition. Even as the contempt petition was pending, the State had come up with a review application, followed by the Minister himself.

☀️ Timings CHENNAI			
TUESDAY, APR. 28			
☀️ RISE	05:50	🌇 SET	18:24
🌙 RISE	15:45	🌇 SET	03:22
WEDNESDAY, APR. 29			
☀️ RISE	05:50	🌇 SET	18:24
🌙 RISE	16:33	🌇 SET	03:58
THURSDAY, APR. 30			
☀️ RISE	05:49	🌇 SET	18:24
🌙 RISE	17:21	🌇 SET	04:34

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	39	26
Chennai Airport	38	28
Chennai City	35	28

Chennai Airport Today
39°C The morning will be comfortable. The day will be hot and uneasy. The night also will be comfortable. Dry weather to occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
38°C The weather will be dry. The day will be slightly hot and uneasy. The night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU
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28th-30th April 2026

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CM YK A CH-CE

Tamil Nadu

From Page One

Tamil Nadu records double-digit growth for second consecutive year

Having recorded two consecutive years of double-digit growth, the State's trajectory reflects "a strong policy framework, a resilient industrial base, a robust infrastructure, and a sustained commitment to inclusive and sustainable development," says K.R. Shanmugam, the former Director of the Madras School of Economics, and also Economic Consultant to the Government of Tamil Nadu.

Over the five-year period (2021-22 to 2025-26), the State achieved an average growth rate of 9.07% annually, marking "a substantial improvement" of 3.86 percentage points over the previous five-year average of 5.21% (2016-17 to 2020-21), and 1.89 percentage points higher than the pre-COVID-19 average growth of 7.18% (2014-15 to 2018-19), Dr. Shanmugam says.

As India's second-largest State economy, Tamil Nadu saw its Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) at current prices rising to ₹35.29 lakh crore in 2025-26 from ₹31.19 lakh crore in 2024-25. This means that "a strong growth" rate of 13.16% has been recorded, the fastest among States. It is built on consistently high nominal growth rates over the recent years: 15.91% in 2021-22, 14.47% in 2022-23, 13.34% in 2023-24, and 15.98% in 2024-25, the economic consultant observes.

The nominal economic growth rate is one that includes inflation. If this aspect is left out, it is called real economic growth rate.

Three sectors

When asked about the three sectors in the previous year, the veteran economist says that the secondary sector – the principal driver of the State's economic expansion – registered around 15% growth rate; the services sector, about 8.5%; and the primary sector, around 6%. Both the secondary and the primary sectors had grown at a higher rate than the national average. What is significant about the component of agriculture this time is that there has been a "notable turnaround" from the previous two years of negative growth rate: -1.96% in 2023-24, and -1.83% in 2024-25. The component, during 2025-26, recorded "a strong recovery", with close to 9% growth.

The State's per capita income (at current prices) now stood at ₹4.08 lakh, second only to Karnataka (₹4.33 lakh), if one is to go by the available data.

62 centres set up across T.N. for counting of votes on May 4

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A total of 62 centres have been set up across Tamil Nadu for the counting of votes polled in the recently held Assembly election. The counting would commence at 8 a.m. on May 4, starting with postal ballots.

At 8.30 a.m., the counting of votes recorded in the Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) would begin.

The final round of the counting of EVM votes would begin only after the counting of postal ballots has been completed, an official release from the Chief Electoral Officer said.

At every counting centre, one section would be dedicated to postal ballots, and one to EVM votes, with the counting being done at designated tables. Separate Assistant Returning Officers would be appointed to supervise each section. "Postal ballots will be counted at a ratio of one table for every 500 postal ballots," the release said. Of a total of 3.60 lakh officials deployed on election duty, 2.88 lakh (80%), who had registered and applied for postal ballots, have cast their votes.

Including police personnel, zonal/sector officers, and members of surveillance teams, about 3.36 lakh election officials voted via postal ballot, while 1.10 lakh officials voted directly at polling stations using Election Duty Certificates.

"Based on Form I2D applications, a total of 1.73 lakh voters (comprising those aged 85+ and persons with disabilities) cast postal ballots," the release said.

HC asks govt. to come up with rehabilitation scheme for transpersons at the taluk level

It asks the government to undo, as far as possible, the historical wrongs inflicted on transpersons, secure for them a life of dignity, equality, and meaningful inclusion as equal participants in the social order, and implement welfare measures for them to attain full development

The Hindu Bureau
MADURAI

The Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has directed the Tamil Nadu government to formulate a comprehensive rehabilitation scheme for transpersons at the taluk level to open up avenues of self-employment and sustainable livelihood and secure a life of dignity for them, and ensure their meaningful inclusion in society, besides implementing welfare schemes tailored to their needs.

The court expresses its profound sorrow as justice has not been done adequately to transpersons, Justice K.K. Ramakrishnan said. He added that the judicial notice acknowledges the prevailing socio-economic conditions of transpersons. In order to



Ensuring adherence: The court has directed the Chief Secretary to file a compliance report on or before July 26.

remedy this situation, the court deems it appropriate to issue certain directions to the government to formulate a comprehensive rehabilitation scheme at the taluk level.

"The court issues appropriate directions to the government to undo, as far as possible, the historical wrongs inflicted upon transgender persons, and secure for them a life of

dignity, equality, and meaningful inclusion as equal participants in the social order, and to alleviate their cosmic sadness and frame and implement effective social welfare measures to enable them to self-sufficiently attain full development with the creation of meaningful economic opportunities, access to education, healthcare, and other essential resources,

and to ensure that transgender persons are brought into the mainstream of society," the judge said.

'No strangers'

"Transgenders are also children of God. Transgender persons are not strangers to our social fabric and the tragedy is not in their birth, it is in the blindness of society which, by exclusion and prejudice, has driven them into conditions of extreme marginalisation such as being driven to beg on the streets or to engage in activities inconsistent with societal norms merely to secure their livelihood and thereby deepening their vulnerability," the judge said.

"There is a total failure of society's collective conscience to embrace diversity with empathy. The court feels that it cannot be said

the Creator has erred. To indict the Creator is to evade human responsibility. The absence of patience and tolerance in society cannot be a ground to deny them dignity. They are entitled to be accepted as equals, as members of families, as participants in the common destiny of this nation. It is no part of judicial function to sit in the theological judgment over the Creator," the judge said.

The court directed the Chief Secretary to coordinate with all the departments concerned to ensure effective and time-bound implementation of the measures, and file a compliance report on or before July 26.

Bail plea

The court was hearing an anticipatory bail petition filed by a YouTuber who

published a video on digital media of an incident of self-immolation by a transperson at a police station in Virudhunagar district. The court granted anticipatory bail to the petitioner on certain conditions.

"At the same time, the court cannot remain oblivious to the tragic incident of self-immolation, which shocked the judicial conscience. The members of the transgender community continue to face entrenched social stigma, resulting in deprivation of basic dignity and meaningful livelihood opportunities," the court said.

(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on the State's health helpline 104, Tele-MANAS 14416, Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050, and Speak2Us helpline at 9375493754.)

T.N. fishermen attacked, robbed of their catch mid-sea

R. Rajaram
TIRUCHI

In separate incidents, 13 fishermen from Nagapattinam district were assaulted mid-sea, allegedly by Sri Lankan Tamil fishermen, and robbed of their catch and their belongings on Sunday night.

One of the suspected Sri Lankan Tamils – identified as Ayanthan, 27, – was nabbed by some fishermen

and brought ashore on Monday morning. He was handed over to the Department of Fisheries.

Police sources said the Sri Lankan fisherman was captured by five fishermen of Serudhur, who put out to sea on a registered fibre boat on Saturday afternoon. They were fishing nine nautical miles south-east of Arcottuthurai when they were intercepted by three suspected Sri Lankans, who

came in a speed boat and tried to cut their nets. However, two of them escaped, and one was captured. He was brought ashore on Monday, and admitted to the government hospital in Nagapattinam for treatment.

In another incident, five Serudhur fishermen, fishing 12 nautical miles east of Arcottuthurai, were intercepted by nine suspected Sri Lankan fishermen, who

came in three fibre boats and threatened them by brandishing knives, before assaulting them. They took away a GPS gadget, a couple of mobile phones, 40 kg of fish, and nets. The fishermen reached the shore on Monday morning, and were treated for injuries as outpatients at the hospital.

Four more fishermen from Serudhur were allegedly assaulted by three suspected Sri Lankans while

they were fishing 12 nautical miles east of Kodiakarai. In yet another incident, four Serudhur fishermen were allegedly assaulted by three Sri Lankans while fishing 12 nautical miles south-east of Arcottuthurai. In both the incidents, the fishermen were robbed of their belongings including a cylinder, a gas stove, a GPS device, mobile phones and 50 kg of fish. They reached the shore on Monday.

Eswari, prime accused in fireworks unit blast, arrested

The Hindu Bureau
VIRUDHUNAGAR

Eswari, the licensee of Vanaja Fireworks at Kattana-rapatti near Virudhunagar, where 25 workers were killed in an explosion on April 19, was arrested on Sunday.

The police said a special team arrested the woman and produced her before a jurisdictional magistrate, who remanded her in custody.

Eswari was the prime accused in the case registered by the Vachchakara-patti police under various Sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita for negligent conduct with respect to explosive substances; disobedience to a lawful order promulgated by a public servant; negligent acts that endanger human life or personal safety; and culpable homicide not amounting to murder.

The police also invoked provisions of the Explosive Substances Act.

Muthumanickam, Eswari's husband, had already surrendered before a court.

The police had also arrested Muthukrishnakumar, who was running the unit on lease, and the accountant, Nandakumar.

Three other persons were arrested for harbouring the absconding accused.

HC dismisses plea seeking inquiry into Vijay's assets

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Monday dismissed a new writ petition for an inquiry into the assets declared by Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) president C. Joseph Vijay while filing his nomination from the Perambur Assembly constituency for the 2026 election.

The First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan refused to entertain the petition, as they had already entertained another case of a similar nature and ordered notice, returnable by June 3, to the Director-General of Income Tax (Investigation). The judges said they shall pass a detailed order by the end of the day, giving reasons for the dismissal of the latest petition. They also dismissed

two other writ petitions that sought a similar inquiry into the assets declared by AIADMK candidates D. Jayakumar and C.Ve. Shanmugam, contesting from Royapuram and Mailam respectively.

The new case against Mr. Vijay had been filed by M.P. Venkatesh, 32, of Kodungaiyur in Chennai. In his affidavit, the petitioner said that as a voter in Perambur, he was entitled to be informed about the financial status of every candidate and the nominees were obliged to make truthful disclosures. He also stated that the disclosure expected to be made by the candidates in Form 26 was not an empty ritual or formality but a substantive constitutional obligation. Any suppression, concealment, misstatement, or manipulation of material particulars would



The judges refused to entertain the petition, as they had already entertained another case of a similar nature against Vijay.

amount to a fraud on the electoral process.

Stating that the actor-turned-politician had projected himself as a proponent of clean and transparent politics, the petitioner said, "However, his own disclosures in the 2026 nomination affidavit reveal substantial financial dealings, including high-value

loans extended to family members and closely connected entities, which have triggered serious public concern and scrutiny."

He went on to state, "The disclosure of a ₹12.6-crore loan to his spouse, Sangeetha, has assumed greater significance in light of widely reported developments concerning ma-

trimonial disputes, thereby raising legitimate questions about the genuineness, purpose, and characterisation of such transactions."

Further, referring to affidavit disclosures regarding loans extended to various other individuals and entities, the petitioner said, "The fifth respondent [Mr. Vijay] has simultaneously declared zero liabilities and no outstanding dues, thereby projecting an artificially sanitised and misleading financial profile. Such contradictory disclosures, including large transfers such as ₹20 crore to Kokilambal Educational Trust, are neither properly explained nor truthfully presented."

Alleging that a bare reading of the election affidavit discloses a "disturbing and consistent pattern of suppression, misrepresentation,

and financial obfuscation," the petitioner sought an inquiry into the issue by the Election Commission of India as well as the Director-General of Income Tax (Investigation).

Previous case

The previous case against Mr. Vijay had been filed by V. Vignesh, another voter from Perambur, who alleged that there was a difference of over ₹100 crore in the assets declared by the TVK leader in the affidavits submitted by him before the Returning Officers in the Perambur and Tiruchi East constituencies, as he was contesting from two constituencies. However, the petitioner had not submitted in the court the amended affidavits, which had been accepted by the Returning Officer of Perambur, and had relied only on a rejected affidavit.

T.N. police track returnees from Southeast Asia in cyber slavery crackdown

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

Cybercrime investigators of the Tamil Nadu police have stepped up surveillance of returnees from the Southeast Asian 'Golden Triangle' region, comprising Laos, Cambodia, and Myanmar, to gather intelligence on cyber slavery networks that operate from heavily guarded scam compounds.

Officials said they were working closely with the Bureau of Immigration and the Protector of Emigrants to get the details of those arriving from these countries. The aim is to identify victims and suspects linked to organised cyber-fraud operations that particularly targeted individuals in India.



The police have intensified their efforts after finding a strong Tamil Nadu connection to online financial scams.

duals in India.

The State police have intensified their efforts after finding a strong Tamil Nadu connection to online financial scams. The investigation revealed that a number of job-seeking youth from the State were trafficked to these coun-

tries and coerced into participating in cyberfraud. In addition, pre-activated SIM cards sourced from Tamil Nadu have been used by fraudsters to carry out scams.

The investigators were coordinating with the Central government agencies and Indian diplomatic missions in the region to rescue victims and prosecute those involved. Data from the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal indicate that around 4,500 online fraud complaints are registered daily across India. In 2024 alone, victims reportedly lost about ₹30,000 crore to such scams.

A recent report by the CB-CID warned that cyber slavery, if left unchecked, could result in significant

economic losses and pose a long-term security threat. "Youth trained in such environments may later attempt to establish similar scam centres in India," the report said, citing recent instances where foreign nationals, in collusion with Indians with experience in scam compounds, attempted to set up illegal SIM box operations in the State.

Cyber slavery typically involves recruitment of educated youth under the guise of lucrative overseas jobs. Victims are lured with promises of high salaries, free accommodation, and other benefits. After virtual interviews conducted on the phone or via video call, they are provided tickets and visas. However, on

reaching the destination, they are trafficked into scam compounds in the 'Golden Triangle' region.

Once there, victims are detained and forced to engage in cyberfrauds, including fake digital arrest schemes, investment frauds, loan app scams, and online romance or matrimonial frauds, targeting victims in India, the United States, and elsewhere, the report said.

A CB-CID officer cited the case of a youth from Tiruvallur district, who paid ₹2.3 lakh to an agent for a job in Cambodia, only to be sold to a scam syndicate. His role involved creating fake social media profiles using images of women sourced from dating platforms, and deceiv-

ing victims online. He was allegedly assaulted when he resisted, and was able to return to India only after paying a ransom. On his complaint, the police arrested seven persons. The investigation revealed that at least 91 victims had previously been trafficked in a similar manner.

Smuggling of SIM cards

A Malaysian national was detained at the Chennai airport for attempting to smuggle SIM cards. Subsequent investigation led to the arrest of 15 individuals, including three more Malaysian nationals, for their involvement in procuring SIM cards, operating mule bank accounts, and facilitating illegal cryptocurrency transactions.

Officials said pre-activated SIM cards were obtained with forged documents, or in the names of unsuspecting individuals. Similarly, mule bank accounts were opened with the identities of vulnerable persons, who were paid commissions. The proceeds of crime were then converted into cryptocurrency and transferred overseas.

T.S. Anbu, Additional Director-General of Police, CB-CID, said the need of the hour was preventive action and creating awareness among the youth. He said students, particularly those in Classes 10 and 12, should be educated on job frauds and the risks associated with overseas employment offers.

Rajiv Gandhi
assassination
case convict,
now a lawyer

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

A.G Perarivalan, one of the life convicts in the Rajiv Gandhi assassination case who was released on remission in 2022, donned the black robes on Monday. He was enrolled into the Bar Association of Tamil Nadu and Puducherry and will practise as an advocate in the Madras High Court. The Supreme Court on May 18, 2022, invoked its extraordinary powers to do complete justice under Article 142 of the Constitution and ordered the release of Mr. Perarivalan in the former Prime Minister's 1991 assassination case.

The top court took into consideration Mr. Perarivalan's long incarceration for over 30 years to order his release. Earlier, his death penalty was commuted to life sentence. Terrorism charges were also withdrawn.

Soon after his release from prison, Mr. Perarivalan joined LLB course in Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Law College, Bengaluru, Karnataka Law University, and completed the course in 2025. He cleared the All India Bar Examination the same year.

Asked how he got interested in becoming a lawyer, Mr. Perarivalan said his long legal battle while in prison inspired him to study law and become an advocate. "My focus will be more on cases relating to anti-death penalty cases human rights," he told *The Hindu*.

SC rejects ex-Minister's plea
in evidence tampering case

Kerala HC had rejected Antony Raju's plea to suspend his conviction to fight polls; SC had earlier restored criminal proceedings against him over allegations of 'interference with judicial processes'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday refused to entertain a special leave petition filed by former Kerala Minister Antony Raju against a Kerala High Court decision to not suspend his conviction in an over two-decade-old case of forging and planting material evidence.

In March, the High Court had refused to accept Mr. Raju's argument that his conviction should be suspended owing to the "special reason" that he was a former Transport Minister and was contesting the Assembly elections. He



No relief: The case involving the former Minister dates back to 1990 when he was a junior lawyer handling a narcotics case. FILE PHOTO

said he risked losing his candidature in the polls if the conviction was not suspended.

The High Court had reasoned that the right to contest an election was not a

fundamental right. It had said that conviction would be suspended only in exceptional circumstances.

In 2024, the top court had restored the criminal proceedings against Mr.

Raju, noting that the case at hand involved "serious allegations of interference with judicial processes which strike at the very foundation of both dispensation and the administration of justice".

The top court judgment had ordered the case records to be returned to the files of the Judicial First Class Magistrate-I, Nedumangad, which was the jurisdictional court. The case dates back to 1990 when Mr. Raju was a junior lawyer in a narcotic drugs case involving an Australian national. He is accused of tampering with the material evidence that was seized in the drugs case.

Mangaluru
cooker blast
case: convict
gets 10-year RI

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

A special court of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) has convicted and sentenced Mohammed Shariq, an alleged operative linked to the Islamic State (IS), to 10 years rigorous imprisonment in connection with the 2022 Mangaluru pressure cooker blast case.

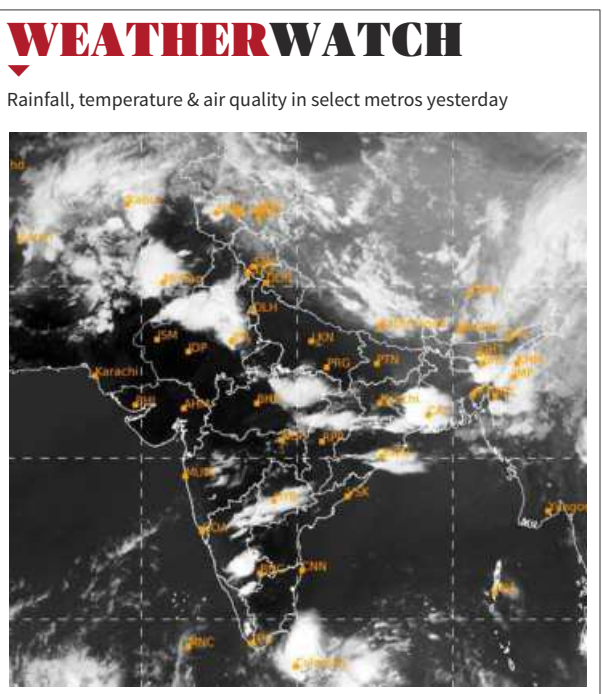
The court also imposed a fine of about ₹92,000 under the provisions of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and relevant sections of the IPC.

The incident occurred on November 19, 2022, at Nagori in Mangaluru, when a low-intensity improvised explosive device (IED) concealed in a pressure cooker exploded while Shariq was transporting it in an autorickshaw. Both Shariq and the driver sustained injuries.

Investigation revealed that the accused had planned to plant the IED at the Kadri Manjunatha Temple, but the device detonated prematurely.

According to the NIA, Shariq had been radicalised into the ideology of IS by associate Arafath Ali, who is already serving a six-year sentence in the Shivamogga IS conspiracy case.

Shariq allegedly conspired with co-accused Syed Yasin and a foreign-based IS handler to carry out terror activities aimed at creating fear through IED attacks. He was also involved in raising funds for the terror outfit.



Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Tripura and West Bengal. Thunderstorm with lightning likely at isolated places over Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala and Mahe. Heat wave conditions likely at isolated places over Gujarat, Rajasthan, Odisha and Telangana

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	44	26.5	19.6	Kozhikode	37	37.2	29.0
Ahmedabad	44	44.2	28.4	Kurnool	42	42.5	30.3
Aizawl	26	25.3	16.8	Lucknow	40	40.3	24.8
Alahabad	44	44.2	26.9	Madurai	40	40.4	27.1
Bengaluru	36	36.3	24.6	Mangaluru	34	34.4	26.6
Bhopal	43	43.4	26.8	Mumbai	34	34.3	27.6
Bhubaneswar	36	36.5	27.6	Mysuru	37	37.2	22.6
Chandigarh	40	40.2	20.8	New Delhi	42	42.3	25.0
Chennai	38	38.1	27.6	Patna	33	33.0	24.4
Coimbatore	38	38.6	25.4	Port Blair	33	33.4	26.7
Dehradun	37	37.9	21.7	Puducherry	35	35.2	27.2
Gangtok	0	19.4	13.9	Pune	42	42.1	26.8
Goa	34	34.9	28.4	Raipur	44	44.2	30.4
Guwahati	5	26.9	20.9	Ranchi	40	40.2	25.0
Hubballi	37	37.0	23.0	Shillong	27	16.5	11.6
Hyderabad	41	41.4	28.5	Shimla	31	31.4	19.2
Imphal	3	21.4	16.8	Srinagar	28	28.5	11.9
Jaipur	43	43.5	30.4	Thiruvananthapuram	35	35.0	26.7
Kochi	33	33.2	28.6	Tiruchi	40	40.3	27.4
Kohima	18	18.0	14.0	Vijayawada	39	39.2	26.8
Kolkata	34	34.1	28.0	Visakhapatnam	32	32.8	28.0

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE
Ahmedabad	60	37	16	70	134	134
Bengaluru	8	11	35	167	175	175
Chennai	4	4	32	75	71	71
Delhi	57	134	61	246	306	306
Hyderabad	21	25	31	62	85	85
Kolkata	17	14	48	39	51	51
Lucknow	12	30	20	188	154	154
Mumbai	29	15	242	210	210	210
Pune	24	113	58	89	89	89
Visakhapatnam	37	42	23	39	120	120

Yesterday

In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Meerut, Uttar Pradesh recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 282 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Ramanathapuram, Tamil Nadu recorded a healthy AQI score of 20

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

A.P. CM to lay foundation stone
for Google's AI data centre today

V. Kamalakara Rao
VISAKHAPATNAM



Arrangements for stone-laying event under way at Tarluvada in Andhra Pradesh on Monday. V. RAJU

Andhra Pradesh is set for a technological leap as Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu will lay the foundation stone for Google's massive \$15 billion (₹1.35 lakh crore) AI data centre hub at Tarluvada, near Visakhapatnam, on April 28.

The event will be attended by Google's senior executives, including Google Cloud CEO Thomas Kurian. The groundbreaking ceremony marks the commencement of one of India's largest single foreign direct investment projects, positioning Visakhapatnam as a premier global destination for artificial intelligence and cloud infrastructure.

The project, managed by Google's subsidiary Raiden Infotech in partnership with Adani Infra, will span 601.4 acres across three strategic locations—Rambilli in Anakapalli dis-

trict, and Adavivaram and Tarluvada in Visakhapatnam district.

With a massive planned capacity of 1 gigawatt, the hub is designed to anchor Google's first major AI-driven data centre campus in India. The infrastructure will feature high-capacity submarine cable landing stations and dedicated fiber networks, providing low-latency connectivity to global markets.

The project is being executed under the State's

'Speed of Doing Business' policy and follows a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signed on October 14, 2025.

The State officials view the investment as a catalyst for long-term economic transformation.

Beyond the core facility, which is slated for completion by July 2028, the project is expected to generate thousands of high-value jobs in data science, cybersecurity, and AI operations. It is anticipated to trigger a ripple effect in allied sectors, including renewable energy systems and advanced manufacturing, reinforcing the State's vision of building a 6.5 GW digital ecosystem.

As the city prepares for Tuesday's launch, the mood remains optimistic, with local leadership hailing the project as a defining moment that will secure Visakhapatnam's place on the global technology map.

School admissions in Kerala may
fall by 1 lakh over new age rule

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A decline of one lakh students is expected in the 2027-28 academic year as Kerala goes ahead with its plan to raise the minimum age for admission to Class 1 from five to six years. The Minister for General Education, V. Sivankutty, re-

cently reiterated that the revised age criterion would come into effect from the 2027-28 academic year.

According to a report submitted by the State Council of Educational Research and Training, children who turn five during the 2027-28 academic year would not be eligible for Class 1 admission, effec-

tively leaving out one batch. The report noted that the transition gap may lead to a decline in student enrolment to Class 1 in 2027-28. The report by the General Education Secretary, pointed out that an additional year of Balavatika (5-6 years) may need to be included at the pre-primary level.

KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar
Bengaluru - 560 009. Phone No. 080-22265383, website: www.kiadb.in
No. IADB/ENGG/ETND-EP-08/214/2026-27 Date: 27.04.2026

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

Item rate Tenders under two cover bid system is invited as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 and Rules 2000 through electronic procurement portal from eligible Contractors who have got adequate financial resources, suitable construction equipments, technical man power & sufficient past experience for the following works :

Name of the Works : 1) Formation of Roads, levelling of park area and Construction of drain, culverts, compound wall at the premises of M/s HAMUL in Subalout-4 Of Hassan Growth centre industrial area, Hassan. 2) Establishment of Plug & Play Infrastructure for Manufacturing / Assembly of Electricity Vehicle Component, battery pack assembly, charging infrastructure and testing centre at plot no.1B of EV Block, Harohalli 5th Phase Industrial Area, Ramanagara Taluk, Bengaluru South District.

The last date and time for receipt of tender is : **14.05.2026 upto 4.00 pm.**

Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer-1, KIADB Bengaluru

DIPR/CP/387/NR/2026-27

E-AUCTION FOR ADVERTISEMENT AT INTERIOR SURFACE OF TRAINS
E-auction for advertisement at interior surface of trains over Tinsukia Division for a period of 03 (Three) years. **Auction Catalogue No.:** TSK-OOH-26-03; **Auction Start Date & Time (All Lots) :** 11:00 hrs. on **14-05-2026**; **Auction Close Date/Time :** 11:30 hrs. on **14-05-2026**. **Rate Unit:** Annual Licensing Fee; **Trips/Days:** 1096.

Seq No.	Lot No./Category	Description
AA/1	ADVT-Int-179116-3-25-1 (Advertisement - Train Interior)	Advertisement at interior surface of 22504 (Vivek Express).

The e-auction catalogue has already been uploaded on 23-04-2026 through IREPS website.

Divisional Commercial Manager (IC), Tinsukia
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
"SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE"

BENGALURU WEST CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer,
Special Division, 2nd Floor, 19th Main, 2nd Block,
Rajajinagar, Bengaluru-560 010.
No:EE/SD/TEND/02/2026-27 Date: 27.04.2026

Invitation for Short Term Tender Notification (IFT)
(Two Cover System) (Through GOK KPPP only)
website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

The Executive Engineer (Special Division), BWCC, Bengaluru invites bids for the following services from reputed Service Provider for the below service.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1.	Selection of a Professional Consultancy Firm for Programme Management and Strategy Support for Bengaluru West City Corporation.

Estimated Amount in Crores (Including GST) : ₹3,67,73,520/-, EMD Amount in ₹: 4,00,000/-.

Calendar of Events: (1) Date of Commencement of Download of Documents from KPP Portal: **30.04.2026**, (2) Date and Time of Pre-bid Meeting on **06.05.2026 at 3:00 p.m.** (3) Last Date and Time for uploading tenders in KPP Portal on : **30.05.2026 upto 4:00 p.m.** (4) Date and Time of Opening Technical Bid on : **01.06.2026 at 4:30 p.m.** (5) Date and Time of Opening Financial Bid on : **02.06.2026 at 4:30 p.m.** (if possible).

Sd/- Executive Engineer, Special Division, BWCC.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

R. SRIRAM
25-07-1965 - 23-04-2026
Former Chairman, NIQR Chennai Branch.
With profound grief, NIQR mourns the passing of Mr. R. Sriram, extends its deepest condolences to the bereaved family and prays for his soul to RIP.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
THIRD DEATH ANNIVERSARY

M. SOLAIMALAI
Born: 03.04.1946 - Died: 28.04.2023
Fondly Remembered by
S. KANNAN
Managing Director
M/s. Pearlconstruction Chennai Pvt. Ltd., MEDAVAKKAN, CHENNAI - 600 100

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
SEVENTEENTH ANNIVERSARY

In ever loving memory of our mother
T.G. LAKSHMI
W/o.(Late) T.G.Gopalakrishnan
Suptg. Engineer (PWD) Retd.
"You live in our hearts"
Fondly Remembered By:
Family Members

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
In Memoriam - Fifth Year Anniversary

DR. H.B.N SHETTY, I.A.S (R)
(11.4.1932 - 28.4.2021)
"Your guidance shaped us and continues to light our way."
In Loving Memory of H.B.N. Shetty
Beloved husband, father, grandfather
We miss you every day.
Shobha, Aruna, Prashanth
Tanvi, Madhav, Antara, Abhinav, Vidhur



Gang of seven

Large-scale defections have rendered the Tenth Schedule impotent

On April 24, seven of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)'s 10 Rajya Sabha members announced their merger with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). The Rajya Sabha Chairman has accepted their claim of merger, raising the BJP's strength in the Upper House to 113 and the combined strength of the National Democratic Alliance above the halfway mark for the first time. The episode highlights the nature of AAP, the crass opportunism of the turncoats, the machinations of the BJP, and the institutionalised defanging of the anti-defection law. Of the seven, Raghav Chadha, Sandeep Pathak and Swati Maliwal were part of AAP in an organic manner, to the limited extent that it had an identity beyond the whims of its founder, Arvind Kejriwal. For the other four, their exit is as opportunistic as their entries into AAP were. Mr. Kejriwal used to taunt the Congress for losing its legislators to the BJP in several States, as symptomatic of the erosion of its ethical responsibility. But a relentless campaign of anarchy in pursuit of power exposed the true character of AAP as a far cry from its grand claims. The disintegration of its Rajya Sabha contingent is the culmination of the cynicism and opportunism on which AAP thrived, imposing a heavy cost on the democratic institutions of India. It reaped what it sowed.

That is no reason to ignore the brazen misinterpretation – invoked by the gang of seven and accepted by the Chairman of the Rajya Sabha – of the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, which bars the defection of elected representatives from their original party. The merger exception in the Schedule is clear that a party can merge with another, subject to the concurrence of two-thirds of its legislators. In 2023, the Supreme Court of India elaborated that the legislature party cannot dictate the course of the political party, and the two cannot be conflated. Two-thirds of the members of the legislature party of the original party must accept a merger for it to be valid under the anti-defection law. To turn this around and argue that two-thirds of a party's legislative members can cross over to another party without attracting disqualification is a stretch, and is being challenged in the Court by AAP. The Court's past interventions on similar developments are less than reassuring, sadly. Elected governments have been unseated on the back of large-scale defections, rendering the Tenth Schedule impotent in the recent past. That the Court could not set any deterrence to this open betrayal of popular mandates is borne out by the fact that such acts are being repeated with impunity.

Culture of violence

Proliferation of guns in U.S. has given a deadly edge to political disagreements

A gunman breached security and fired shots at the annual dinner gala of the White House Correspondents' Association in Washington DC, which included U.S. President Donald Trump and other senior administration officials, all of whom escaped unharmed. The suspected shooter, said to be Cole Tomas Allen (31) of Torrance, California, was arrested. This is the third incident of violence apparently targeting Mr. Trump, after a previous occasion on which a would-be assassin's bullet grazed the president's ear at a campaign rally, and another in which a gunman was apprehended near a golf course frequented by Mr. Trump. The suspect in this case is said to have “clearly stated” that he wanted to target administration officials, according to the White House, and in a note by the suspect shared by law enforcement officials, he said that he could no longer allow a “traitor to coat my hands with his crimes”. The incident comes in the wake of several high-profile attacks on political figures in recent years. These include the September 2025 killing of Charlie Kirk in Utah, the murder of Minnesota Democratic State Representative Melissa Hortman and her husband a few months earlier, and the 2022 attack on Paul Pelosi, the husband of former Democratic House Speaker Nancy Pelosi. It also comes after more than a year of Mr. Trump's second term in office, a period marked by increasing polarisation over key policies, including immigration, and his association with disgraced financier and convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

While bitter partisanship has long marked U.S. politics, it is the ubiquitous proliferation of guns that has truly supplied a deadly edge to disagreements in the public discourse. Ironically, the Trump administration has been at the forefront of efforts to protect the U.S. Constitution's Second Amendment, the right to bear arms, to the point where it is often in alignment with the position of the National Rifle Association (NRA) in terms of reversing reasonable restrictions on gun ownership. For example, Mr. Trump supported a ban on assault weapons in 2000, yet he reversed his position by the time he launched his 2016 presidential campaign, one that was backed by millions of dollars spent by the NRA. The U.S. has been periodically wracked by mass shootings, including three this year, and more than 500 over the past 60 years, according to databases tracking such incidents. Notwithstanding the deep pockets and lobbying power of the NRA and its ilk on Capitol Hill, it behoves the U.S. to take a step back from the brink of this unrelenting gun violence epidemic and bring common-sense gun reforms to the table, then to be enacted into law by Congress. Until such time as society and popular culture move towards a more moderate position on gun laws, it is reasonable to believe that violence of the kind routinely witnessed across the country will continue unabated.

The Election Commission of India (ECI) has invented the term “logical discrepancy” to delete voters from the voters' list in the recent elections (the States of Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal, and the Union Territory of Puducherry). It is alleged that lakhs of voters have been removed from the voter list in States where elections have been held recently. Even the Supreme Court of India's innovative idea of tribunals could not get these voters back onto the list, mainly because of the near-total mess created by the ECI's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls exercise.

It has been pointed out by many commentators – including this writer in this daily – that the SIR, as designed by the ECI, is deeply flawed and, if continued, will result in the elimination of a very large number of Indian citizens from the electoral roll. Media reports indicate an alarming situation, particularly in West Bengal, where lakhs of genuine citizens have had their names removed from the electoral roll and placed under the category of “logical discrepancies”. The fact is that many of them were unable to vote in the election/first phase of the election.

Citizenship as basic requirement

The issue of the elimination of people from the voter list revolves around the question of citizenship. Article 326 enjoins that every person who is a citizen of India and who is not less than 18 years of age and who is not disqualified under the Constitution or law shall be entitled to be registered “as a voter at any election”. Thus, citizenship is the basic requirement for anyone to be registered as a voter.

The citizenship law is administered by the Union Home Ministry. Therefore, it is the duty of the Ministry to announce the list of documents required to prove the citizenship of Indians. However, as far as is known, the Ministry has not issued any such list.

Instead, the ECI announced a list of documents at the time of initiating the SIR in Bihar. Since many documents that citizens normally use for various purposes, such as Aadhaar card, ration card, and even the photo voter identity card issued by the ECI itself, were not accepted by the ECI as proof of citizenship, people began running



P.D.T. Achary

Former Secretary General, Lok Sabha

Voter deletions under the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls raise concerns over constitutional and procedural validity

helter-skelter in search of the documents listed by the ECI. Many of such documents were hard to find, especially for rural people who are not in the habit of preserving such documents. Thus, as many as 91 lakh voters were removed from the voter list in West Bengal because they could not produce the documents that the ECI required to prove their citizenship

Duty of the Home Ministry

A question of great constitutional significance arises here. Does the ECI have the power under Article 324 to determine what documents the citizens should produce to prove their citizenship? The simple answer is that such power is vested in the Union Home Ministry, and it is the constitutional duty of the Home Ministry to announce publicly the documents required for this purpose. The ECI can only verify those documents while enrolling citizens in the voters' list. Here, the ECI is acting beyond its jurisdiction. Article 324 does not empower the ECI to usurp the power of the Home Ministry. But it is surprising that the Supreme Court did not address this question when the issue of documents came before it. It was expected that the Court would direct the Union government to announce the list of documents and submit an affidavit in this regard. Instead, the Court merely requested the ECI to consider whether the Aadhaar card could also be counted as a relevant document.

The SIR has been conducted in the election-bound States, deviating from the law. Section 21 in The Representation Of The People Act, 1950 says that the electoral roll shall be revised before each general election and before a bye-election and also in any year as directed by the ECI. Apart from these the ECI can also undertake a special revision of the roll of a constituency or part of it for reasons to be recorded. Rule 25 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 explains that the revision can be done summarily or intensively, which makes it clear that pre-election revision is summary in nature and the revision done in any year (when there is no election coming up) is intensive.

A combined reading of Section 21(2) of The Representation Of The People Act, 1950, and Rule 25 of the Registration of Electors Rules makes it clear that only a summary revision of the rules

can be done before the general election or any bye-election.

The intensive revision can be done at any other time when elections are not due, the reason being that such a revision is very comprehensive and the voters' list needs to be prepared afresh. It is a very time-consuming exercise and cannot be done in such a hasty manner. The SIR conducted by the ECI a couple of months before the Bihar election, and, thereafter, in Kerala, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal is thus a clear deviation from the law and past practice.

In West Bengal, where the SIR exercise was absolutely chaotic, over 91 lakh voters have been removed from the voter list, many of whom have been placed in the category of “logical discrepancy”. This categorisation of citizens is unknown to the election law. The Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 lays out a detailed scheme for the preparation of the electoral roll. Besides, the ECI has issued detailed instructions, one of which is that the booth-level officers (BLOs) should distribute enumeration forms to all existing electors through house-to-house visits.

Rule 8 clearly states that the occupants of the dwelling houses shall furnish the information called for to the best of their ability. This should mean that the ECI will have to accept the information that the occupants of the house have collected to the best of their ability. It makes no sense for the ECI to insist on obtaining information that, in the normal course, is not possible to procure, particularly for unlettered rural people in remote parts of the country. The fact that 64 lakh voters in Bihar and 91 lakh in West Bengal were removed from the voters' list amply demonstrates the deliberate non-adherence to this and other rules by the ECI.

An instance of violations

The object of this hastily conducted SIR seems to be to remove millions of voters from the voters' list. Media reports suggest that much of these deletions have been done without giving those affected a hearing, which is a blatant denial of natural justice as well as a violation of statutory provisions. Free and fair elections cannot be ensured by deviating from or violating the statute. The justice system in the country cannot permanently turn a blind eye to it.

A tightening of the fist in India's digital public square

Imagine this. You leave a sharp, satirical comment on social media or under a news article about rising fuel prices, and it gets a few likes. A few hours later, the comment disappears. The platform does not explain. Your account remains, but you notice that posts on similar topics no longer appear publicly. You have not been charged with any offence. No court has issued an order. Yet something has quietly shifted.

This is not a far-fetched scenario. It is a plausible outcome under the draft amendments to India's Information Technology Rules released by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) on March 30, 2026. Presented as technical clarifications, the changes mark a deeper transformation in how speech is governed online and who gets to decide its limits.

Core area of concern

At the centre of concern is a proposed expansion of executive power that risks bypassing Parliament and the courts. One provision, Rule 3(4), would require platforms to comply with a wide array of government-issued instruments, including advisories, directions and standard operating procedures, as a condition for retaining “safe harbour” protection under Section 79 of the IT Act. In plain terms, platforms would be legally safer if they follow government instructions, even when those instructions do not arise from formal law.

This sits uneasily with the Supreme Court of India's landmark ruling in *Shreya Singhal vs Union of India* (2015), which held that platforms are only required to act on unlawful content when they receive a court order or a government notification grounded in law. By allowing informal directives to trigger compliance obligations, the draft rules appear to dilute that constitutional safeguard.

The likely result is not targeted moderation but broad over-censorship. Faced with uncertain and potentially unpublished directives, platforms will err on the side of removal. It is the predictable



Vikram Raj

Journalist associated with the Internet Freedom Foundation

The draft amendments to India's Information Technology Rules trigger fears of digital overreach and a departure from existing judicial rulings

logic of risk management. When liability is unclear, speech becomes expendable.

A second shift expands the scope of state oversight far beyond traditional publishers. Amendments to Rule 8 bring ordinary users who post or share news and current affairs content within the ambit of the government's oversight mechanism. This includes the Inter-Departmental Committee, a body empowered to review content and recommend blocking.

This is not merely an administrative adjustment. It reintroduces, through a different route, a regulatory framework that has already faced judicial scrutiny. In 2021, the Bombay High Court stayed key provisions of the IT Rules, citing concerns under Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution. The Madras High Court later observed that such oversight could undermine media independence. Those challenges remain pending. Yet, the new draft effectively reconstructs the same architecture while those questions are unresolved.

An undefined role

Equally troubling is the transformation of the Inter-Departmental Committee itself. Originally designed to address grievances, it is now empowered to examine any “matter” referred by the Ministry of Information and Broadcasting. The term is left undefined. A procedure is currently in place under Rule 14 but compliance remains an issue. There is no clear threshold for intervention, and no guarantee that affected users will be heard before action is taken.

This shift from grievance redress to proactive scrutiny changes the character of the body. It becomes less a forum for dispute resolution and more an instrument of preemptive control.

The third major concern lies in expanded data retention obligations. The draft clarifies that platform duties to retain user data operate in addition to requirements under any other law. In practice, this could mean that personal data, browsing activity and communication records are stored for extended periods, potentially years,

depending on overlapping legal mandates.

The risks here are not abstract. Longer retention increases the surface area for misuse, whether through unauthorised access, data breaches or function creep. It also alters the relationship between citizens and digital spaces. When every interaction may be archived indefinitely, self-censorship follows naturally.

Taken together, these amendments signal a shift toward a model where executive discretion plays a dominant role in shaping online speech. The concern is not only about individual provisions but about their cumulative effect. Each change reinforces the other. Informal directives gain force through safe harbour rules. Oversight expands to include ordinary users. Data retention deepens the state's informational reach.

Upsetting the balance

Supporters of the policy may argue that governments require flexible tools to manage harmful content. That is true in principle. But constitutional systems impose limits on how that power is exercised. Delegated legislation must remain within the bounds of its parent statute, a principle affirmed in cases such as *Indian Express Newspapers vs Union of India* (1986). When rules begin to create new obligations that are not clearly grounded in law, the balance between regulation and overreach begins to tilt.

The short public consultation period, which ended on April 14, only heightens the concern. Changes of this magnitude deserve wider debate, legislative scrutiny and careful alignment with existing judicial rulings.

India's digital public sphere has grown precisely because it has allowed a diversity of voices, from professional journalists to ordinary citizens. That openness has always required some regulation. The question now is whether the new rules preserve that openness or narrow it through administrative control.

The answer will shape not only how platforms operate but also how freely citizens can speak, critique, and participate in public life.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Bite of the serpent

Snake bites are often treated symptomatically when antivenom serum is not readily available, and such treatment is often unsuccessful. Even when antivenom is available, its effectiveness against the specific venom involved in the bite is questionable. Reporting snake bites along with the species involved would be helpful in preparing species-specific antivenom serum to be used in a strategic manner. There are tribes traditionally involved in snake rescue in different States, and many times they are not readily

available for the job. They can also be encouraged to train prospective snake rescuers.
Dr. V. Purushothaman,
Chennai

I write this letter as Assistant Professor of Forensic Medicine and Toxicology, Government Medical College, Ongole. India bears the world's highest burden of snakebite mortality, yet it continues to rely largely on polyvalent antivenoms designed for a limited set of species. This approach overlooks significant regional variation in venom composition, often resulting

in suboptimal efficacy, higher dosing requirements, and adverse reactions. Identifying the ‘offending’ species through rapid tests will have limited clinical impact unless matched by equally precise, venom-specific therapeutics. There is a need to invest in venomics-based research and in the development of regionally tailored or monovalent antivenoms. While such efforts are resource-intensive, they are justified by the scale of mortality and economic loss associated with snakebites.
Dr. K.A.R. Reddy,
Ongole, Andhra Pradesh

Raghu Rai

The passing of Raghu Rai reminds us that photography can be both witness and conscience. His lens chronicled wars, tragedies and captured portraits of leaders and ordinary citizens with equal empathy, turning fleeting moments into enduring truths. Rai believed that every frame carried meaning, and his work proved that history is not only written but also seen. His images of the Bhopal gas tragedy, Operation Blue Star, and the quiet dignity of everyday life remain etched in the nation's memory. They will teach

generations that light and shadow are not just technical elements but reflections of human resilience. India has lost a visionary who revealed its soul through images.
K. Chidanand Kumar,
Bengaluru

Raghu Rai was a poet among photographers who told heart-touching verses through the frames he captured. His photograph, the ‘Burial of an Unknown Child’, is a haunting image that captures the horror of the 1984 Bhopal gas tragedy.
M. Pradyu,
Thalikkavu, Kannur, Kerala

Raghu Rai was an institution in himself. Two of his iconic images are still alive in my memory — Indira Gandhi's body lying in state, surrounded by red roses, her sari covering her head, and her distinctive nose pointing upwards, just before her funeral, which was on the front cover of *India Today*. The second was of a dead child partially buried in rubble, which was a haunting image of the Bhopal gas tragedy.
Saurabh Sinha,
Bhilai, Chhattisgarh

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Can middle school students engage with AI?

Recently, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) decided to introduce a Computational Thinking (CT) and Artificial Intelligence (AI) curriculum for classes 3-8, which will begin from the 2026-27 academic session. CT skills generally refer to abstraction, decomposition, pattern recognition, and algorithmic thinking. These skills are required to reason about intelligent systems and to understand how machine learning differs from rule-based computation. As with any transformational reform in education, it is necessary to examine the practicality of introducing computational concepts to middle school learners. Will it align with age-appropriate pedagogy for engaging with emerging digital and computational environments?

Global precedents

One first has to examine whether CBSE's curriculum clearly links CT and AI, since such a relationship is conceptually necessary. The foundational design principle behind the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development and the European Commission's AI Literacy Framework identifies CT as a precursor to AI learning. This framework recommends CT competencies across age bands beginning from early primary school. Similarly, the A14K12 Initiative in the U.S. places CT-related competencies at the base of its "Five Big Ideas in AI." Their CT-competencies progression plan spans K-2, 3-5, 6-8, and 9-12 grade bands. The CBSE's sequencing broadly aligns with these comparative curricular architectures. However, its curriculum is designed independently in line with the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE), 2023.

UNESCO also identifies topics such as "What is AI?",



Mamidala Jagadesh Kumar

Chairman, Review Committee for NEP 2020, Ministry of Education and former Chairman, UGC. Views are personal

The CBSE curriculum includes introductory discussions on AI fairness, responsible use, and digital safety. This focus is broadly consistent with cross-national practices

"Foundations of computing", and "Data literacy" as necessary for school students. Learners need to start cultivating logical thinking from an early stage and gradually build problem-solving skills. They also need opportunities to develop a basic understanding of AI as part of their broader digital learning.

Tackling inherent risks

There are, of course, risks associated with children interacting with AI. The CBSE curriculum includes introductory discussions on AI fairness, responsible use, and digital safety. This focus is broadly consistent with cross-national practices. For instance, the A14K12 guidelines include topics such as recognising when AI systems may mislead; identifying bias in datasets; and distinguishing between AI and human capabilities across all age groups. But can children meaningfully engage with such content at a young age? Classroom-based interventions, including studies conducted in U.S. middle schools, led to interesting outcomes. They suggest that learners in the 11-13 age group can engage with AI ideas when supported by structured pedagogical interventions. These studies reveal that introducing ethical dimensions of AI at this stage can be pedagogically feasible.

A growing body of empirical research suggests that introducing concepts such as supervised learning or predictive modelling is viable for learners in the 11-14 age group. Many comprehensive research studies on AI in K-12 education suggest that school-age participants as young as 10-12 years can work with fundamental AI concepts. Thus, the CBSE's CT-AI framework appears compatible with the learning capacities observed in this age group.

Many international initiatives encourage the use of no-code tools for introductory AI learning. Multiple empirical studies show that by using such tools, middle

school learners can design, build, test, and reflect on their projects without coding. For this reason, the CBSE's expectation that Class 8 students can attempt to solve real-world problems using no-code tools is supported by several international initiatives.

However, children may start attributing human-like traits or capabilities to AI tools, although these tools do not actually possess them. Does the CBSE curriculum address this challenge by creating awareness among children? The CBSE's curriculum contains topics discussing ethical use, fairness, and responsible digital behaviour. Such discussions can help reduce children's misconceptions about AI. These modules can support better understanding and the prudent use of AI systems.

The CBSE curriculum follows a cross-disciplinary design by integrating CT into Mathematics and 'The World Around Us' course for Classes 3-5. Global experiences which involved cross-disciplinary instructional models reported improvements in students' reasoning and problem-solving in several contexts. The CBSE's pedagogical orientation reflects similar design principles.

Away from rote learning

One problem in Indian education is the habit of rote learning. CT and AI learning have the potential to encourage inquiry-driven, reflective learning rather than traditional rote-based methods. The CBSE curriculum emphasises practical modelling, reflection, and ethical reasoning. This approach can therefore contribute to ongoing efforts to move classroom practices away from rote-based methods.

International practices and available research suggests that middle school is an appropriate stage to introduce foundational CT-AI elements. The CBSE's CT-AI curriculum is structured to make thoughtful and effective use of this developmental stage in learners' growth, and it exhibits coherence with the vision of the NEP 2020.

No rest for the wicked

Even as the State comes down from its election high, tensions are still rising

STATE OF PLAY

T. Ramakrishnan
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The period between the date of polling and the date of counting votes should normally be quiet. But, in Tamil Nadu, which saw a record voter turnout of 85.1% with about 4.88 crore people casting their votes on April 23, an intense debate is on about a host of issues.

The issues vary from the advisability of Chief Minister M.K.Stalin taking a holiday in Kodaikkanal to the comparative performance of Tamil Nadu with other southern States with respect to the Information Technology (IT) sector to the possibility of a coalition regime getting formed due to the presence of the Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK) led by actor C. Joseph Vijay.

The Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) former State president and the party's candidate for Mylapore, Tamilisai Soundarajan, in a post on her social media handle, criticised the holiday of Mr. Stalin, and the visit of his son, Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin, along with his family to an overseas country. She recalled that it was the same Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) party that had levelled criticism in the 1950s against then Chief Minister K. Kamaraj's trip to Udhagamandalam.

But what is becoming more controversial is the conversation around the ruling DMK's contribution to the IT field and reported criticism among sympathisers of the ruling party about sections of young employees in the sector not being loyal to the organisation in view of their perceived support to the TVK. With respect to the IT sector, pro-DMK acti-

vists are quick to point out that the seeds for the present situation in the State were sown by the DMK regime in the 1990s when Tamil Nadu became the first State in the country to come out with a policy document on the sector in 1997. However, critics refer to the wide gap in the value of exports recorded by Tamil Nadu vis-a-vis its two southern neighbours, Telangana and Karnataka, and question whether any purpose is served by just claiming to be the trendsetter. According to information furnished in the Lok Sabha during March 2025, Tamil Nadu's IT exports in 2023-24 were ₹80,677.43 crore whereas the figures for Telangana and Karnataka were ₹1,21,116.62 crore and ₹4,09,095.04 crore respectively.

Possibility of coalition

Even though people of the State have given a decisive verdict in favour of one political party or the other in 14 out of 16 occasions since 1952, the talk of Tamil Nadu likely to witness a coalition government this time began among sections of the intelligentsia in the last phase of the poll campaign. As the TVK is an untested force with no consensus among experts as to whose votes it will take away in the event of the fledgling party making a dent, the talk has acquired greater strength.

Known for their opposition to the idea of a coalition regime, the two Dravidian majors are confident of victory on their own. The recent entrant is also hoping to capture power on its own. The last occasion when the State witnessed a three-cornered contest was in 1989, the first election after the death of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) founder M.G.Ramachandran. At that time, the DMK bagged a clear-cut majority on its own. The front led by the party secured 170 seats with a vote share of about 38% while the AIADMK (Jayalalithaa)-led coalition bagged 32 seats with 24.4% of votes polled. The Congress alliance got 27 seats with 21.4% of the vote share. There was also one more front headed by AIADMK (Janaki Ramachandran) which got one seat but with a vote share of 10.87%.

Even though leaders of all the parties have greeted the people for the record voter turnout this time, there is an element of jubilation in the message of the TVK chief who has sought to view the turnout as an endorsement of him. Possibly, his enthusiastic portrayal is based on the visible presence of younger generations turning up to vote, which is, however, not uncommon in any poll in the State. At the same time, the two Dravidian majors are sure of their success and, according to a leading Tamil daily, they are even preparing themselves for the swearing-in ceremony. Regardless of all these points and counterpoints, what is becoming apparent is that the grip of the bipolar system over the State is receiving pushback, and the two established players will have to come to terms with the third force, which may not turn out to be a pushover.

BJP's rapid rise in Assam is more pronounced in ST seats

The 2026 results will reveal if the BJP will retain its ST-seat stronghold or concede ground to the Congress that is trying to bounce back

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis
Devyanshi Bihani

As the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) waits for the counting on May 4 to see if it will retain power in Assam for a third consecutive term, a look at the Assembly polls since 2006 in the biggest northeastern State shows how sudden the growth of the BJP has been and how the growth is more pronounced in the seats reserved for Scheduled Tribes (STs).

Assam has a total of 126 seats, of which 16 are reserved for the STs, who account for 12.4% of the State's total population of 3.12 crore as per the 2011 Census. Until 2006, the BJP had not won a single ST seat in Assam in any of the Assembly polls.

In the 2006 Assembly elections, the BJP, which had by then been in power at the Centre for the first time, from 1998 to 2004, won three ST seats and 12 seats overall (Chart 1). In the 2011 polls, its performance worsened as it could win only five seats overall and none of the ST seats.

The BJP's rise to power at the Centre in 2014 had a huge impact in Assam as can be seen in the sudden and massive upturn in its fortunes in the 2016 Assembly polls (Chart 2). Its rise coincided with the erosion of vote shares of not just the Congress, its major rival, but also other regional parties like the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), which had once ruled Assam.

From drawing a blank in all the 13 ST seats it contested in 2011, the BJP managed to win eight of the 10 ST seats in 2016. It had roped in the AGP and the Bodoland People's Front (BOPF) into the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) as minor allies. The coalition together won 14 out of the 16 ST-reserved seats. In 2021, though the hit rate of the BJP (seats contested versus seats won) came down overall, it managed to increase its tally in ST

seats by winning nine of the 10 seats it contested.

Meanwhile, the Congress-led alliance, which is fighting the 2026 polls under the banner of the Asom Sonmilito Morcha (ASM), was gradually losing its footing within these seats. In 2001 and 2011, the Congress won eight and nine ST seats out of the 12 and 16 it contested respectively (Chart 4).

The Congress-led alliance's decline and the BJP-led NDA's ascent is revealed better in the vote shares of the two national parties, besides the seats they managed to win. As Chart 5 shows, Congress managed to regain some of its lost ground in terms of its overall vote share in Assam in 2021 even though it did not win. However, its vote share in the ST seats was still lower than what it had secured in 2006.

Moreover, the vote share of the BJP in ST seats has seen a steep rise from a meagre 7.1% in 2011 to 41.7% in 2016 and a whopping 54.4% in 2021.

Fight for ST status

The 2026 results will reveal if the BJP will retain its stronghold in the ST seats or concede ground to the Congress that is desperately trying for a comeback in the State.

Interestingly, the demand for ST status to six communities, including the Tai Ahoms, the Adivasi 'tea tribes', Chutia, Koch-Rajbanshi, Matak, and Moran, who together account for roughly 30% of the State's population is getting louder, a demand that the winning party has to reckon with.

During the BJP's 2014 Lok Sabha campaign, Prime Minister Narendra Modi promised that ST status will be granted to these communities. However, the BJP is yet to fulfill the promise despite being in power in the centre and winning two consecutive terms in Assam.

With the granting of ST status being a key promise of the ASM in the 2026 polls, the results on May 4 will reveal if this promise has resonated with these communities.

Tribal turnaround

The data for the charts were sourced from Lok Dhaba, a project of the Trivedi Center for Political Data, a research centre led by faculty members in the Political Science and Computer Science departments of Ashoka University

CHART 1: Seats contested by the BJP-led alliance versus seats won in ST-reserved Assam Assembly constituencies

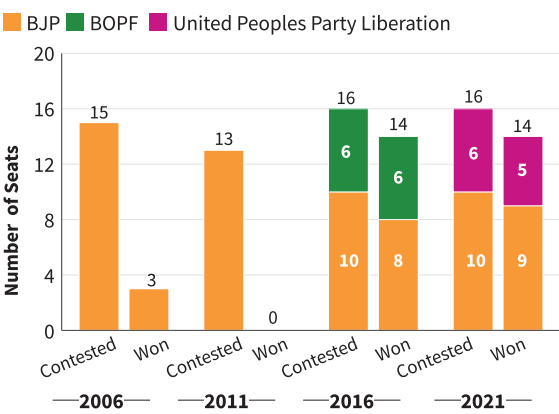


CHART 2: Seats contested by the BJP-led alliance versus seats won in all Assam Assembly constituencies over the years

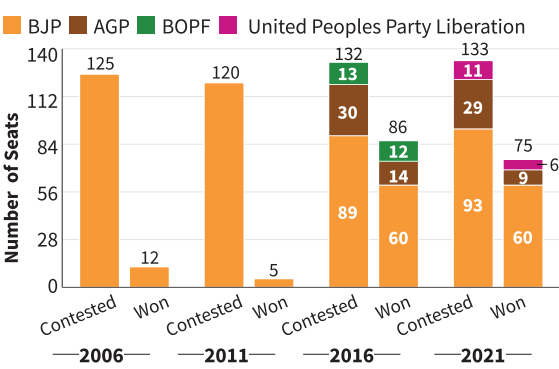


CHART 3: Seats contested by the INC+ alliance versus seats won in all Assam Assembly constituencies

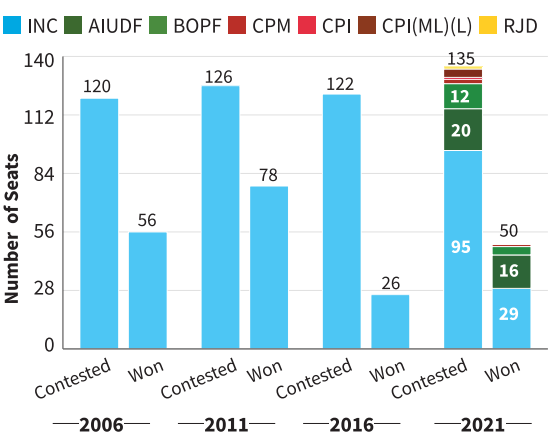


CHART 4: Seats contested by the INC+ alliance versus seats won in ST-reserved Assam Assembly constituencies

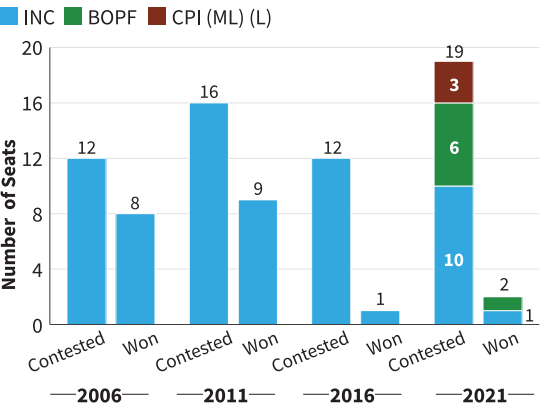
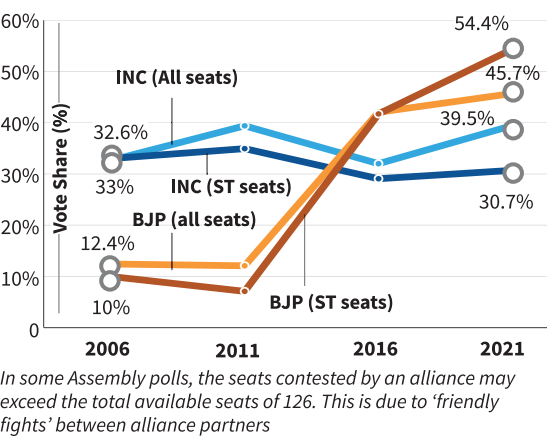


CHART 5: Alliance-wise vote shares in the Assam Assembly polls across all constituencies and ST-reserved constituencies



In some Assembly polls, the seats contested by an alliance may exceed the total available seats of 126. This is due to 'friendly fights' between alliance partners

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu**.

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 28, 1976

Ground water potential in Coromandel Belt

Madras, April 27: An integrated inter-disciplinary approach should be made to the development of the entire coastal belt between Tiruvannmiyur and Mahabalipuram, Mr. M. S. Balasundaram, former Director-General, Geological Survey of India, said here to-day.

Presiding over a workshop on "Groundwater Potential in the Coromandel Series of Rocks along the East Coast" he said the series could be taken as a single unit and investigation conducted in an integrated manner by all disciplines. The approach to development should cover land utilisation, urbanisation, groundwater exploitation and the like.

The workshop was organised by the GSI to place before experts in various official agencies the data collected by it on the groundwater potential in the Tiruvannmiyur Covelong belt. Since the water crisis of 1975, one million gallons of water is being drawn daily from this source to meet a part of the needs of Madras. Cautioning against large-scale pumping of water from the belt, Mr. Balasundaram said one had to ascertain first what quantity could be drawn safely without seawater interference and without the aquifers getting contaminated. He felt the data gathered over a year would not be adequate for arriving at a "safe conclusion". Inaugurating the workshop, Mr. S. Panchanathan, Chief Engineer (Groundwater) Public Works Department said that with the almost full utilisation of surface water resources groundwater had assumed great importance for Tamil Nadu.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 28, 1926

Giant motor caravans for Gwalior

London, April 27: "The Westminster Gazette" says that two giant motor caravans for hunting purposes, capable of accommodating 16 persons fully furnished and lit by electricity, which had been ordered by the late Maharaja of Gwalior, are being shipped to India from England this week. The front portion of so-called "Flat-a-van" consists of a vehicle driven by 50 H.P. Engine and in which eight people can dine at once. Behind is a trailer equipped with a dormitory. The whole outfit is 45 feet long, weights ten tons and costs £3,000.

Campaign season ends, Bengal parties switch to silent mode

Nearly 3.21 crore voters across 142 constituencies and seven districts will determine the fate of 1,448 candidates when voting will be held tomorrow; Mamata, Suvendu Adhikari among key leaders in the fray; EC has stepped up security for the polls

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Campaigning for the second and final phase of the West Bengal Assembly election concluded on Monday.

Nearly 3.21 crore voters across 142 constituencies and seven districts will determine the fate of 1,448 candidates when voting is held on Wednesday. The votes for the Assembly election will be counted on May 4. The first phase saw a record-breaking turnout of over 90%.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee were among the leaders who canvassed for their party candidates on the last day of campaign. Mr. Modi addressed an election rally at Barrackpore in North 24 Parganas district and declared that once West Bengal gets a Chief Minister from the Bharatiya Janata Party, both the Chief Minister and Prime Minister will work for the development of the State.

"You have given the Congress, Left Front, and Trinamool Congress 70 years. Now, give us a chance just once... Together, we will free West Bengal from all shackles," Mr. Modi said.

Later in the day, the Prime Minister released an



Final push: West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee during a roadshow in Kolkata on Monday; and (right) Union Home Minister Amit Shah campaigning in Kolkata. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



audio message exuding confidence that the BJP would form the next government in the State. Mr. Modi said he would "celebrate the oath-taking ceremony together with the people". "Despite addressing so many rallies amid the intense heat, I did not feel even the slightest fatigue during this election campaign in West Bengal. These rallies, these roadshows... I felt as if I was on a pilgrimage," he said.

Shah's promise

Union Home Minister Amit Shah participated in the last leg of campaign in the Behala area of Kolkata, and said the Central Armed Police Forces would stay put in the State for 60 days and voters should not be intimidated. "Don't worry about *Didi's* [Ms. Banerjee] goons; the Election Com-

mission has deployed CAPFs at every nook and cranny. Today, I'm saying it as I go – after the elections, a BJP government is coming. Even then, CAPFs will stay right here for the next 60 days," Mr. Shah said.

Ms. Banerjee held three roadshows during the day in different areas of the city – Dhakuria, Gariahat Road, and Hazra. Trinamool general secretary Abhishek Banerjee addressed public meetings in Haringhata and Dhaniakhali and held a roadshow in Arambagh, where tension erupted after an attack on the vehicle of Trinamool MP Mitali Bag.

Ms. Bag alleged that the BJP's "goons" had vandalised her car at Goghat in Hooghly district when she was on her way to the rally of Mr. Abhishek Banerjee. "Those who laid hands on

a marginalised woman... after 12 noon on May 4, I will see how much power they have. I will see how your leaders from Delhi are able to save you," she said.

More incidents

Tensions were also on the rise in the Jagatdal constituency of North 24 Parganas after a clash between supporters of BJP candidate Arjun Singh and Trinamool candidate Somnath Shyam. The vehicle of Trinamool leader Saokat Molla was attacked at Bhangar in South 24 Parganas district. Similar allegations were made by Indian Secular Front (ISF) leader Nawasad Siddique in the same constituency. At several places in the districts going to the polls, crude bombs were recovered by the police.

CAPFs go 'all out' to win 'trust' ahead of last phase of Bengal Assembly polls

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

As West Bengal heads into the final phase of the Assembly election, the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) have launched extensive patrolling operations named "All out, night dominance, *Kavach* (shield), trust" to ensure a secure polling environment, a CAPF official said.

More than 100 armoured and anti-riot vehicles have been deployed across sensitive areas to instil confidence among voters, the official said. The intensified security measures include round-the-clock area-domination exercises, night patrols and high-visibility movement of forces.

Approximately 2.4 lakh CAPF personnel have been deployed across the State for the last phase of polling on Wednesday, in addition to the State police. West Bengal has witnessed poll-related violence in the past.

Asked about the rationale of giving such an operational name for patrolling duties during an Assembly election, the official said, "All of us are out in the field to ensure that the elections are held in free and fair manner, that is why the name is 'all out'. Night dominance means that security forces are present in huge numbers and there is no need to be



Police and security personnel conducting a flag march and interacting with people in Purba Bardhaman on Monday. ANI

intimidated. There have been several instances when people have come to us and conveyed that they were able to vote after 20-30 years."

The Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) has posted about such initiatives on social media platforms.

'Atmosphere of peace'

"OPERATION ALL OUT PHASE II Day-and-night patrolling and naka checking by CAPFs continue in sensitive areas. A strong security presence has fostered trust and an atmosphere of peace among the general public," said West Bengal Sector, CRPF, Kolkata, in a post on X on Monday.

Another post said, "Extensive flag marches and area domination operations are being conducted by Central Armed Police Forces during Phase-2 of the West Bengal elections. Objective – to build confidence among voters and

ensure a fear-free environment."

At least 85 companies of CAPFs or around 8,500 personnel were withdrawn from the ethnic violence-affected Manipur and moved to West Bengal for the elections. A CRPF official said the force does not have personnel in reserve and to fulfill election responsibilities, troops were pulled out from Jammu & Kashmir, Manipur and Left-wing Extremism-affected areas.

Ahead of the first phase of elections on April 23, a district-wise list of around 1,100 'troublemakers' was circulated among the CAPF personnel across the State. The list, according to which detentions were to be made and warnings issued, mostly comprised people associated with the Trinamool Congress, including legislators. It was stayed by the Calcutta High Court.

Seizures of inducements in Bengal surpassed ₹510 crore: EC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of the final phase of Assembly election in West Bengal on Wednesday, the Election Commission on Monday said total seizures of illicit inducements in the State surpassed ₹510 crore.

The amount is higher than the ₹339 crore seized during the 2021 election and also exceeds recoveries made in the State during the 2024 Lok Sabha election, a senior official said. The ₹510-crore recovery includes ₹30 crore in cash, over 48,000 litres of liquor worth ₹126.85 crore, drugs valued at ₹110.12 crore and precious metals, including gold and silver, worth ₹58.28 crore.

Enforcement agencies have also seized freebies worth ₹184.85 crore, including household items, apparel and cellphones.

Review meetings

The poll body said it held multiple review meetings with Chief Secretaries, CEOs, DGPs, and senior officers from the poll-bound States/Union Territories and their neighbouring regions, along with the heads of enforcement agencies. They were directed to ensure violence-free, intimidation-free and inducement-free elections, the EC said in a statement.

To ensure enforcement, over 2,728 flying squads have been deployed to respond to complaints within 100 minutes. Besides this, over 3,142 static surveillance teams (SSTs) have been deployed for *naka* checking at different locations. Special drives are being conducted against the manufacture, storage and distribution of illicit liquor, it said.

Mamata, Cabinet Ministers face tough poll contests in Kolkata and its suburbs

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

The second phase of the election to 142 Assembly seats in West Bengal on Wednesday will decide the fate of more than half a dozen Ministers along with Chief Minister and Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee.

While Ms. Banerjee is locked in a bitter electoral contest for the Bhabanipur seat in south Kolkata against Bharatiya Janata Party leader Suvendu Adhikari, her Cabinet colleagues are contesting seats in and around the city.

Kolkata Mayor and State Urban Development Minister Firhad Hakim is seeking re-election from the Kolkata Port constituency. Mr. Hakim, a prominent Muslim leader of the Trinamool Congress, is facing Rakesh Singh of the BJP and Faiyaz Khan of the Communist Party of India (Marxist).

Another prominent Minister facing the electoral contest is Aroop Biswas from Tollygunge. Mr. Biswas, who, as the Sports Minister, faced criticism for the chaos during an event of footballer Lionel Messi in Kolkata, is contesting against Papiya Adhikari of the BJP and Partha Pratim Biswas of the CPI(M).

Sovande Chatteropadhyay, another senior Minister in the State Cabinet, is contesting the Ballygunge seat. Mr. Chatteropadhyay, who served as the Agriculture Minister, is pitted against Shatorupa of the BJP and the CPI(M)'s new face Aftab Begum.

In the northern parts of Kolkata, the Trinamool's Shashi Panja is contesting



Poll clash: Kolkata Mayor Firhad Hakim during a door-to-door campaign for the West Bengal Assembly elections. ANI

from the Shyampukur constituency against Purnima Chakraborty from the BJP and Jhuma Das from the All India Forward Bloc (AIFB).

On the northern fringes of Kolkata, Education Minister Bratya Basu is contesting from Dum Dum against Arijit Bakshi of the BJP and Mayukh Biswas of the CPI(M). In adjoining Dum Dum Uttar, Finance Minister (Independent Charge) Chandrima Bhat-tacharya is seeking re-election and is pitted against Sourav Sikdar of the BJP and Dipsita Dhar of the CPI(M).

Highest deletions

Kolkata and the adjoining areas have voted for the Trinamool across several elections in the past, but this time the candidates of the ruling party are facing tough contests from the candidates of the BJP and Left Front. There are 11 Assembly constituencies in Kolkata, which has seen the highest number of deletions during the special intensive revision of poll rolls.

Debasish Kumar and Atin Ghosh, key Trinamool leaders who are the party's faces in the Kolkata Municipal Corporation, are contesting the Rashbehari and Kashipur Belgachia seats, respectively.

Of the 142 seats that are going to the polls in the second phase, 111 are in the Presidency region. These seats are spread across North 24 Parganas (33), South 24 Parganas (31), Nadia (17), Howrah (16), and Kolkata (11) districts. The Trinamool Congress won 96 of them, the BJP 14 and the others one in the 2021 Assembly election.

The Presidency Division is the bastion of the Trinamool Congress, though in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, the BJP increased its vote share in these districts and led in 21 Assembly segments, while the Trinamool was ahead in 90 seats.

The other two districts going to the polls in the second phase are rural Purba Bardhaman with 16 constituencies and Hooghly with 18 constituencies that comprises both urban and rural settlements. These regions had also overwhelmingly voted for the Trinamool Congress in 2021.

The deletions of electors during SIR, safety of women, welfare schemes of the Ms. Banerjee-led government, Matua citizenship, agrarian distress and 15 years of anti-incumbency sentiments against the Trinamool will seal the fate of the candidates.

Rajya Sabha Chairman accepts the merger of seven AAP MPs with BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Rajya Sabha Secretariat on Monday updated the party-wise list of members in the House, counting Aam Aadmi Party MP Raghav Chadha and six others with the Bharatiya Janata Party, indicating that Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan has accepted their request to switch sides.

With the change, the BJP's strength in the Upper House has risen to 113 while the Congress, the largest Opposition party, remains a distant second with 29 members.

Welcoming the seven MPs in a post on X, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijji said: "For a long time, I have observed that these seven Hon'ble MPs have not resorted to abusive language and have never created indiscipline or indulged in unparliamentary conduct. Wel-



Joining hands: Rajya Sabha members Raghav Chadha and others meeting BJP president Nitin Nabin in New Delhi on Friday. ANI

come to nation building NDA under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister @narendramodi ji and goodbye to the Tukde-Tukde INDI Alliance."

On Friday, seven of the AAP's 10 Rajya Sabha members – Mr. Chadha, Ashok Mittal, Sandeep Pathak, Harbhajan Singh, Rajendra Gupta, Vikramjit Sahney and Swati Maliwal – quit the party and submitted a letter to the Rajya Sabha Chairman informing

him of their "merger" with the BJP.

The AAP reacted on Sunday with its Rajya Sabha leader Sanjay Singh filing a petition seeking their disqualification, calling the move a violation of the anti-defection law. "The Chairman has taken cognisance of the letter submitted by those seven MPs and, based on that, accepted their merger. The objections raised by us and the disqualification sought un-

Congress alleges AAP gave Rajya Sabha seats for money

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Monday accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) of being engaged in a "fixed match", alleging that recent political developments had exposed a tacit understanding between the two parties and reinforced its claim that the "AAP was working as BJP's B team" in the States such as Gujarat and Punjab.

Addressing a press conference here, party treasurer Ajay Maken alleged

that the AAP had been giving Rajya Sabha ticket to the rich and wealthy in exchange for money and should thus change its name to the "*Arabpati Aadmiyon ki Party* (party of billionaires)".

Targeting the BJP, Mr. Maken said it had secured a disproportionate share of Rajya Sabha representation from Punjab despite having a limited electoral base in the State. He said the BJP had polled around 6% of the vote in the 2022 Punjab Assembly election, but following the defection of seven AAP Rajya Sabha

members, its representation from the State in the Rajya Sabha had gone up to 86%.

He alleged that the AAP had worked as a proxy of the BJP to counter the Congress in States like Punjab and Gujarat. He alleged that the party's claim of representing the "common man" stood undermined and claimed that the average declared net worth of the seven AAP Rajya Sabha members who joined the BJP was over ₹818 crore, arguing that this reflected a pattern of privileging wealthy candidates.

Disqualify MLAs who cross-voted: BJD to Speaker

The Hindu Bureau
BHUBANESWAR

The Biju Janata Dal on Monday met Odisha Assembly Speaker Surama Padhy and demanded the disqualification of eight MLAs who, it said, had voted against the party's decision in the Rajya Sabha election. "We also want these MLAs to tender their resignation on their own, and seek a fresh mandate from their respective constituencies," BJD Chief Whip Pramila Mallick said.

INBRIEF



Oil India reports hydrocarbon discovery in its block in Libya

State-owned Oil India has reported an oil and gas recovery from its exploration block in Libya. The oil and gas explorer holds 25% participating interest in the consortium, which also includes IndianOil, for the onshore exploration block Area 95/96 in Ghadmames Basin of south-western Libya. The block holds eight exploratory wells, with drilling of five wells completed and four reporting discoveries between 2012 and 2014.

ONGC okays JV with MRPL, OPaL on petrochemicals

State-owned explorer ONGC said it had approved the formation of a joint venture company with subsidiaries Mangalore Refinery Pvt. Ltd. (MRPL) and ONGC Petro additions Ltd. (OPaL) integrating the petrochemical marketing divisions of the companies. ONGC would hold 50% stake in the joint venture, with the rest being divided equally among the two subsidiaries, it informed the bourses on Monday. “The joint venture company will reduce costs and increase revenue through improved pricing mechanism, logistics and grade optimisation and production of speciality grades,” MRPL said adding, “Creation of the joint venture company will also open an opportunity for undertaking third-party sales considering the import dependency of the nation in certain petrochemicals.”

SEBI urged to probe ₹275 cr. fund diversion in slum project

A Mumbai-based complainant has urged the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to investigate alleged fund diversion, investor cheating and money laundering involving more than ₹275 crore in a Slum Rehabilitation Authority (SEA) project at Khot Dongri in Malad East. The complaint filed by Nikesh Raghani relates to a redevelopment project under the SRA scheme at Rani Sati Marg, on about 5,600 sq. metres. It names Shah Housecon Pvt. Ltd., B Right Real Estate Ltd., B Right promoter Sanjay N. Shah, Mansukh Shah and Akash Shah of Shah Housecon, and Premji Shah of Royal Realtors Landmark Pvt. Ltd. as beneficiaries.

TRAI attempts to promote public WiFi hotspots, again

NEWS ANALYSIS
Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI



Public hotspots have been beset by many issues.

Since at first it did not succeed, TRAI’s trying again. The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) came out with a consultation paper seeking a response to the question it asked in 2016: how can public WiFi hotspots take off? As the three private telcos steadily implement tariff hikes, this may be a timely shot at a familiar problem for the government. Public hotspots have been beset by many issues. For one, WiFi access/giga-byte is far cheaper than even Indian mobile data prices but mobile data is still pretty inexpensive, constraining demand at scale. A second issue is telcos and Internet service providers’ aggressive campaign against public WiFi, by charging them enterprise-leased line rates costing lakhs a year, pricing out small shops where access points can make a difference.

Hotspot ID friction
But the bigger issue may be the government’s insistence on complete visibility of the identity of every individual connecting to a WiFi hotspot with an OTP or some other form of ID verification. This norm was put in place in 2009 and has no equals in most

of the world. The 2009 requirements followed terrorist attacks in Ahmedabad and Mumbai. but their utility in signals intelligence and combating crime is questionable. TRAI’s paper moots a “super-aggregator” to facilitate “inter-hotspot roaming” and “a centralised-platform-for-authentication” authentication.

ISP pushback
Further centralisation and more efficient surveillance of WiFi hotspots has been tried. The results speak for themselves. The PM-WANI architecture targeted 10 lakh hotspots under a Public Data Office-type arrangement. To date, less than half that number has been rolled out, four years after the deadline. Fixed line connections still cost money to build and is usually the post-network build-out generation that leverages the abundance of the networks to

Fertilizer security strong, stable, well-managed: Centre

For Kharif 2026, the Ministry of Fertilizers has assessed requirement of 390.54 LMT, the current available stock of 190 LMT is 49% of the requirement, says Additional Secretary

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Amid criticism by the Opposition that the Centre had failed to ensure availability of cooking gas and fertilisers, the Union Fertilizers Ministry said here on Monday that the country’s Fertilizer security remained “strong, stable, and well-managed,” with availability consistently exceeding requirement across all major Fertilizers.

‘Prices unchanged’
Addressing an inter-ministerial briefing on the impact of the recent developments in West Asia on the availability and production of Fertilizers, Aparna S. Sharma, Additional Secretary, Department of Fertilizers, said retail prices of Urea, Di Ammonium Phosphate (DAP) and Triple Superphosphate (TSP) would remain unchanged at



Clearing the air: Ms. Sharma said a total of 190.21 LMT of fertilizers was available, compared with 169.24 LMT last year. R. VENAGESH

₹266.5, ₹1,350 and ₹1,300 per bag respectively. The overall stock position of Fertilizers in the country is improved, with urea stock of 71.58 lakh metric tonnes (LMT) as of now compared with 70.67 LMT on the same day last year. DAP stock remains at 22.35 LMT, compared with 15.07 LMT last year. 57.56 LMT of Nitrogen (N), Phosphorus (P), and Potassium (K) Fertilizers are available. Last year, the stock was

44.49 LMT. Stock of Single Super Phosphate (SSP) is 26.26 LMT. This was 26.14 LMT last year. 12.46 LMT of Muriate of potash (MOP) is available, compared with 12.87 LMT last year, on the same date. Ms. Sharma said a total of 190.21 LMT of Fertilizers was available, compared with 169.24 LMT last year. For Kharif 2026, the Ministry has assessed Fertilizer requirement of 390.54 LMT and the current avail-

RBI tightens bad loan rules to align with global norms

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has rejigged the rules governing classification of bad loans, definition, and recovery, to align with globally-accepted standards, effective April 1, 2027, according to the Master Directions released on Monday. According to one of the revised directions, if one loan of a borrower with many loans is classified as

a non-performing asset (NPA), all the other loans would also be considered so. The basis for classifying a loan as NPA, however, remains at 90 days overdue. An NPA borrower will be considered a “standard asset” only “on repayment of entire arrears of interest and principal pertaining to all the credit facilities,” as per the revised norms. The new regulation also directs banks to establish automated systems to identify NPAs.

Sun Pharma to buy U.S. firm Organon in \$11.75 bn all-cash deal

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Sun Pharmaceutical Industries said it agreed to buy all outstanding shares of U.S. firm Organon for \$14/share in an all-cash transaction at an enterprise value (EV) of \$11.75 billion. A global leader in women’s health, Organon’s portfolio includes more than 70 products across women’s health and general medicines, including biosimilars, commercial-

ised across 140 countries. This global footprint is supported by six manufacturing facilities across the EU and emerging markets. On successful consummation of the transaction, Sun is poised to be among the top 25 global pharmaceutical firms with a combined revenue of \$12.4 billion, a leading player in established brands and branded generics. The deal also enables Sun’s entry into biosimilars as a top-10 global player.

**TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED**
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Under taking & and an ISO 27001-2022 Certified Company)

TENDER NOTICE
The APTRANSCO invites bids online for the following work with Spec. No: PMMTC1-e-22/2026. Name of the Work: Selection of a qualified, experienced and DGCA-compliant Drone Service Provider for drone-based monitoring of transmission line assets covering approx. 23,000 towers / 8,500 KM (400 kV / 220 kV / 132 kV) of APTRANSCO focusing on tower and line corridor inspection including vegetation clearance with validity for 2 years. Date & Time of availability of Tender on e-procurement platform i.e., www.tender.approcurement.gov.in is on **28.04.2026 at 17:00Hrs.** Contact No. **Dy.EE: 9491008564.**
RO.No : GMCC/APTRANSCO/20/26-27 **Sd/- CHIEF ENGINEER,TELECOM & IT**

**PSPCL Punjab State Power Corporation Limited**
(Regd. Office : PSEB Head Office, The Mall, Patiala)
Corporate Identification Number (CIN) U40108PB2010SGC033813
Website: www.pspcl.in (Contact No. 9646123323)

Tender Enquiry No. PPR-10/2026 Dated: 26.04.2026
Chief Engineer/PP&R Organization, Shed No. D-3 Shakti Vihar, PSPCL, Patiala invites E-tender under three part bid system for supply of electrical energy from interstate / intrastate sources viz Generators, Traders having valid Inter State Trading License issued by CERC for interstate trading of energy, intrastate trading license issued by PSERC for Intrastate trading of energy, State Electricity Boards, State Electricity Utilities, States, IPPs & CPPs from 15th May 2026 to 30th September 2026. The link for the e-Bidding portal is www.mstcecommerce.com and is also available on the website of Ministry of Power (www.Powermin.nic.in) and PFC Consultancy Limited (www.pfcindia.com). For detailed NIT & tender specification please refer to www.mstcecommerce.com from 26.04.2026 onwards. **Note:** Corrigendum and addendum, if any, will be published online at www.mstcecommerce.com
1079/12/2026-27/10915 C 533/26

Govt. doesn’t foresee any requirement for importing petrol or diesel, says Ministry

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The government does not foresee any situation where the country may be required to import petrol and diesel, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) told reporters at the inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia Monday.

Responding to a query on the availability of stocks, the senior official told reporters, “As far as the supply of diesel and petrol in the country is concerned, I want to re-emphasise we have sufficient stocks. Sometimes because of the panic buying, there may be an issue but then that issue is taken on priority and is resolved.” “We do not foresee any situation where we have to go for import of petrol or diesel,” she added.

‘Panic buying’
Concerns over availability of the retail fuels, that is, petrol and diesel, and a potential increase in prices have led to panic buying. Last week, the government had refuted assertions about considering any increase in prices of the two retail fuels.

In fact, *The Hindu* had reported earlier in the day that several retail outlets in Andhra Pradesh were facing logistical issues in replenishing stocks only every two days because of the panic buying. This led to certain outlets putting up ‘No Stock’ boards. Addressing the same at the inter-ministerial briefing here, Ms. Sharma informed that there had been instances of “exceptional growth” in demand in certain areas. “We have observed exceptional



HPCL asserted on Monday that fuel availability in A.P. was adequate and stable.

growth in certain areas like 30-33% in HSD sales. That is the reason certain retail outlets have faced the [stock] situation,” she stated, adding, “We are monitoring the situation, and I am sure by today evening, all the stocks would be available at all the retail outlets.”

Additionally, State-owned oil-marketing company Hindustan Petroleum asserted on Monday evening that fuel availability in Andhra Pradesh was “adequate and stable.”

‘Temporary surge’
It said a “temporary surge” in demand was observed in the previous two to three days because of panic buying of petrol and increased consumption of diesel with the ongoing agricultural season. “This has led to higher-than-normal sales at retail outlets,” the refiner posted on social media, adding, “For petrol, the February average sales were 1.8 thousand kilolitres (TKL), which increased to 2.46 TKL on April 25, and 2.35 TKL on April 26. Similarly, for diesel (HSD), the February average of 2.37 TKL rose to 3.36 TKL on April 25, 2026, and 3.12 TKL on April 26.”

**Government of Rajasthan**
National Health Mission, Rajasthan
Department of Medical, Health & Family Welfare, Swasthya Bhawan, Jaipur.
Tel. No. 0141-2225736, E-Mail ID: gemh-raj@gov.in

No.- 242 Date:- 20.04.26
Short Term E-NIT No-07 /2026-27 on EPC MODE
Online tenders are invited in prescribed format from experienced contractors registered in Public Works Department/State Government/ Authorized organizations of Central Government/ Central Public Works Department/Department of Posts and Telecommunications/ Railways etc. in appropriate category for Building Construction works on EPC Mode in Medical and Health Department, Rajasthan, who are equivalent to the contractors of appropriate category of Rajasthan Government.

Total number of Works	01
Total NIT cost (Rs. in lakhs)	3360.00
Date of online download & upload	21 April 2026 to 30 April 2026 Evening 6:00 PM
Date of technical Bid opening	01 May 2026 11:00 AM

Details related to the tender can be seen on DIPR website www.dipronline.org, www.sppp.raj.nic.in <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> and departmental website <http://rajsvasthya.nic.in>.
UBN:-

S. No.	UBN Number
1	NRH2627WLOB00070

DIPR/C/7305/2026
Chief Engineer
Medical and Health
Rajasthan, Jaipur

**BENGALURU SOUTH CITY CORPORATION**
Office of the Executive Engineer, Traffic Engineering and Mobility Cell, 2nd Floor, 9th Main Road, Jayanagara South 2nd Block, Bengaluru -560 011.

No. EE/BSCC/TE&Mcell/TEND/02/2025-26 Date: 27.04.2026
SECTION I: INVITATION FOR TENDER (IFT)
(Through GOK KPP Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> only)
The Executive Engineer Traffic Engineering and Mobility Cell invites tenders from eligible Tenderers for the works detailed in the table below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
T.E.C work as per requirement of Bengaluru traffic police for the work of Providing Scientific Humps, HRPC, Lane Dividers, Thermoplastic Paint & other Road Safety Works in 1. Arterial and Sub-Arterial Roads in South Zone. Appx. Amount put to tender: 159.85 Lakhs (Exclusive of GST), EMD : Rs. 2,40,000/- (Rs. one lakh Through e-payment & remaining as specified in bid document)	

Calendar of Events : (1) Availability of Tender Document in KPPP portal : **28.04.2026** (2) Date and time of per-bid meeting : **05.05.2026 at 11:00 Hrs** (3) Last date & time for Queries (only through online): **05.05.2026 at 16:00 Hrs** (4) Last Date & Time for receipt of Tenders : **11.05.2026 at 16:00 Hrs** (5) Opening of Technical bid : **13.05.2026 after 16:30 Hrs** (6) Opening of Financial bid (if possible): **14.05.2026 at 11.30 Hrs.**
Sd/- Executive Engineer Traffic Engineering and Mobility Cell, BSCC

**भारतीय अंतरिक्ष विज्ञान एवं प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान**
Indian Institute of Space Science and Technology
(वि. अ. आयोग अधिनियम 1956 की धारा 3 के अधीन मानित विश्वविद्यालय घोषित)
(Declared as Deemed to be University under Section 3 of the UGC Act, 1956)
भारत सरकार, अंतरिक्ष विभाग के तहत स्वायत्त संस्थान
(An Autonomous Institute under Department of Space, Govt. of India)
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Valimala, Thiruvananthapuram 695 547, Kerala
NAAC द्वारा 'A++' मान्यता प्राप्त / NAAC 'A++' Accredited

पीएचडी कार्यक्रम में प्रवेश जुलाई सत्र - 2026
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आवेदन प्रक्रिया केवल ऑनलाइन रूप से ही की जाएगी
Application process will be done ONLINE only
पीएचडी कार्यक्रम में प्रवेश के लिए सूचना नीचे दी गई वेबसाइट पर उपलब्ध है।
Notification for admission to Ph.D.programme is available at:
<https://admission.iist.ac.in>
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Last date to apply: 25th May 2026
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संपर्क सूत्र / Contact 0471-2568477/ 618 (on working days 0900 - 1700 hrs)
डीन (अकादमिक) / Dean (Academics)

WASHINGTON

Britain's King Charles III arrives in the U.S. for a four-day state visit



Britain's King Charles III arrived in the United States on Monday for a four-day state visit, as tensions simmer over the Iran war. The trip by King Charles and Queen Camilla is intended to honour historic ties between the two countries as the U.S. marks its 250th anniversary, according to the U.K. government. AFP

MANAMA

Bahrain revokes citizenship of dozens over Iran-linked activities



Bahrain's Interior Ministry said on Monday that the kingdom has revoked the citizenship of 69 people for their support of Iran after weeks of Iranian attacks on Gulf states. A top rights group said it was "the first mass revocation of citizenship since 2019". The move comes as Gulf states are on high alert over Iranian infiltration. AFP

BEIJING

China vows countermeasures if EU enacts 'Made in Europe' plan



Beijing slammed on Monday an EU plan aimed to bolster the bloc's industries against competition from China, vowing action if it is enacted. The EU unveiled in March "Made in Europe" rules for firms trying to access public funds in sectors including cars, green tech and steel, obliging them to meet thresholds for EU-made parts. AFP

VATICAN CITY

Pope Leo prays with first woman Anglican leader in historic meet



Catholic leader Pope Leo XIV prayed on Monday in the Vatican with the Archbishop of Canterbury, Sarah Mullally, and vowed to keep working to overcome differences in a historic meeting with the first female leader of the Church of England and spiritual leader of the global Anglican Communion. AP

Hezbollah rejects Israel-Lebanon direct talks; Aoun pledges to end war

The Lebanese group's chief calls direct talks a 'grave sin' that will destabilise the country; President says those dragging Lebanon into war were committing 'treason'; Israeli attacks killed over 2,500 people, according to Lebanese authorities

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT

Hezbollah leader Naim Qassem on Monday rejected Lebanon's planned direct negotiations with Israel, calling them a "grave sin" that will destabilise Lebanon.

Shortly after, Lebanese President Joseph Aoun took a jab at the Iran-backed group, saying those who dragged the country to war were committing "treason".

Lebanon and Israel's U.S. Ambassadors met twice in Washington over the past weeks, the first meetings of their kind in decades, for talks that



Under occupation: Israeli soldiers walking along a road between destroyed houses in southern Lebanon on Monday. AFP

were rejected by the Hezbollah.

After the first round of talks, U.S. President Donald Trump announced a 10-day ceasefire that came into effect on April 17, later announcing a three-week

extension after the second round of talks.

"We categorically reject direct negotiations with Israel, and those in power should know that their actions will not benefit Lebanon or themselves," Mr.

Qassem said. He called on authorities to "back down from their grave sin that is putting Lebanon in a spiral of instability".

President hits back
Lebanon's President said that direct negotiations with Israel were aimed at ending the war with Israel.

"My goal is to reach an end to the state of war with Israel, similar to the armistice agreement" of 1949, President Aoun said. The two countries have officially been at war since 1948.

"Was the armistice agreement a humiliation? I assure you that I will not accept reaching a humiliating agreement."

Mr. Aoun said: "What

we are doing is not treason. Rather, treason is committed by those who take their country to war to achieve foreign interests".

Lebanese authorities have stated that the goal of the U.S.-led negotiations is to stop the war and secure Israel's withdrawal from southern Lebanon.

"These direct negotiations and their outcomes are as if they do not exist for us, and they do not concern us in the slightest," Mr. Qassem said. "We will continue our defensive resistance for Lebanon and its people," he added.

Israeli attacks killed over 2,500 people since the start of war on March 2, according to authorities.

U.S. shooting suspect charged with bid to assassinate Trump

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

The man who authorities say tried to storm the White House Correspondents' Association dinner with guns and knives has been charged with the attempted assassination of U.S. President Donald Trump.

He appeared in Washington federal court on Monday to face charges in a chaotic encounter that resulted in shots being fired, Mr. Trump being rushed off the stage and guests ducking for cover underneath their tables.

Cole Tomas Allen, 31, was taken into custody after the shooting on Saturday night. Authorities say an officer wearing a bullet-resistant vest was shot but is expected to recover.

"He attempted to assassinate the President of the United States," prosecutor Jocelyn Ballantine said in court.

Mr. Allen left a manifesto with family members referring to himself as the "Friendly Federal Assassin" and discussing plans to target senior Trump administration officials, authorities said.

He also was charged with transport of a firearm



Agents stand alert after loud bangs were heard at the White House Correspondents' dinner in Washington, DC, on Saturday. AFP

and ammunition in interstate commerce and with discharging a firearm during a crime of violence.

Mr. Allen is believed to have travelled by train from California to Chicago and then onto Washington, where he checked himself in as a guest at the hotel where the gala dinner was held, acting Attorney General Todd Blanche said.

(With inputs from Reuters)

Two killed in Ukrainian strike as Russian attack wounds 14

Associated Press
KYIV

A Russian drone attack before dawn on Ukraine's southern city of Odesa wounded 14 people, including two children, authorities said on Monday, in the latest barrage of civilian areas that have been a hallmark of Moscow's full-scale invasion.

Meanwhile, a Ukrainian drone strike killed two people in the Russia-occupied part of Ukraine's southern Kherson region, Moscow-installed Governor Vladimir Saldo said on Monday. A man and a woman in their 70s died in the village of Dnipriany, he said.

In Odesa, drones hit residential neighbourhoods

Russia fired nearly 1,900 attack drones, and around 60 missiles at Ukraine over the past week, says Zelenskyy

and civilian infrastructure, said Serhii Lysak, the head of the city's administration. Russia has repeatedly targeted Odesa, a key Black Sea port for Ukraine, since Moscow launched the war in 2022.

Five of the wounded, most of them with shrapnel wounds, were hospitalised, according to Oleh Kiper, the head of the regional military administration.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on

Monday that Russia has fired approximately 1,900 attack drones, nearly 1,400 powerful guided aerial bombs and around 60 missiles of various types at Ukraine over the past week.

Ukraine's wartime development of cutting-edge military technology means that it's intercepting more than 90% of the drones that Russia launches, Mr. Zelenskyy said in an X post. However, Kyiv needs more American-made Patriot air defence missiles, which are able to shoot down Russia's ballistic missiles.

Meanwhile, Ukraine has been assailing oil terminals and refineries in Russia with long-range drones and missiles, aiming to disrupt Moscow's economy.

Merz says Iran 'humiliated' U.S. in rebuke as talks stall

Reuters
BERLIN

German Chancellor Friedrich Merz said on Monday Tehran was humiliating the United States and getting their officials to travel to Pakistan and then leave without results, in an unusually abrupt rebuke over the conflict.

"The Iranians are very skilled at negotiating, or rather, very skillful at not negotiating," he said.

"An entire nation is being humiliated by the Iranian leadership, especially by these so-called Revolutionary Guards. And so I hope that this ends as quickly as possible," he said.

China blocks Meta acquisition of AI start-up Manus amid U.S. tech rivalry

Associated Press
HONG KONG

China on Monday blocked U.S. tech giant Meta's acquisition of the artificial intelligence startup Manus, in an unexpected move to reverse a deal that apparently aroused Beijing's concerns about the transfer of advanced technology.

In a one-line statement, China's National Development and Reform Commission, the country's top planning agency, said it was prohibiting a foreign acquisition of Manus and had required all the parties to withdraw from the deal.

The decision by the commission's Office of the Working Mechanism for Security Review of Foreign



Artificial apprehensions: The decision reflects Beijing's concerns about transfer of advanced technology. REUTERS

Investment came after Chinese authorities said they were looking into the deal earlier this year.

The commission did not elaborate on the reasons for the ban.

The announcement came less than a month before U.S. President Donald Trump's planned visit to Beijing to meet Chinese leader Xi Jinping in May, in a sign that China's communist leaders are tightening scrutiny of the AI industry amid intensifying geopolitical rivalry with the United

States over the technology. Meta announced in December that it was acquiring Manus, which has Chinese roots but is based in Singapore, in a rare case of a major U.S. tech group buying an AI company with strong links to China. Its deal with Manus, whose "general-purpose" AI agent can perform multi-step complex work autonomously, was expected to help expand AI offerings across Meta's platforms.

Meta said on Monday that the Manus transaction "complied fully with applicable law."

"We anticipate an appropriate resolution to the inquiry," the California-based company said in a statement.

THE HINDU GROUP

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A dedicated publication for our young readers, that beats the trap of doom scrolling with curiosity driven learning.

A new edition for teens COMING SOON

SETTING THE STANDARD

Kohli has changed the way people see the sport, says Krunal



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

On Virat Kohli becoming the first to reach 9,000-run milestone in IPL, RCB teammate Krunal Pandya said: “Virat is one of the greatest to have played... His achievements have been unbelievable. With his consistency and hunger, he has changed the way people see the sport. He has also been the flag-bearer for fitness culture in India”.

BIG BOOST

Starc to be available for Capitals’ next game against Royals on Friday



FILE PHOTO: R.V. MOORTHY

On a bleak day for Delhi Capitals, the silver lining that emerged was that star pacer Mitchell Starc will be available for the side’s next outing against Rajasthan Royals in Jaipur on Friday. “He will be available from May 1 as per the NOC he has got from Cricket Australia,” DC skipper Axar Patel said on Monday.

IN AND OUT

Mumbai Indians names Maharaj as a replacement for injured Santner



AMOL KARHADKAR

Mumbai Indians has drafted in Keshav Maharaj as a replacement for the injured Mitchell Santner, who has been ruled out of IPL 2026 with a left shoulder injury. Maharaj, a left-arm spinner who has also led South Africa in T20Is, joined the squad ahead of MI’s home match on Wednesday against Sunrisers Hyderabad.

SHOWING DISSENT

Raghuvanshi penalised for Code of Conduct breach against LSG



R.V. MOORTHY

KKR’s Angkrish Raghuvanshi was fined 20% of his match fee and handed one demerit point for breaching the IPL Code of Conduct during the match against LSG. After being given out for Obstructing The Field, Raghuvanshi was seen striking the boundary cushion with his bat in frustration before throwing helmet into the dugout.

Bhuvneshwar, Hazlewood blow away DC

The two experienced pacers share seven wickets to shoot out the host for 75; defending champion RCB romps home in just the seventh over

IPL-19

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

The venue was Delhi. The format was T20. But at the start of Monday’s fixture at the Arun Jaitley Stadium in IPL 2026, Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Josh Hazlewood were so irresistible with the new ball that the proceedings resembled a Test match unfolding on a green deck in Duneidin.

If Bhuvneshwar teased Delhi Capitals’ batters with swing from a good length, Hazlewood tormented the opposition with the short delivery. The deadly combination broke the back of the host inside the PowerPlay, and made victory for Royal Challengers Bengaluru a matter of formality.

Procession

Both pacers scalped three wickets each in their opening spells as Capitals were incredibly reduced to eight for six in 3.5 overs, with the scores of the top six reading 0, 1, 1, 0, 5, 0. The record of the lowest total in IPL history – 49 by RCB against Kolkata Knight Riders in 2017 – was in danger for a while, but Abishek Porel and David Miller put together 35 for the seventh wicket to avert that ignominy.

Eventually, Hazlewood finished with figures of 3.3-0-12-4 as DC folded up for 75. The defending champion took just 6.3 overs to clinch a nine-wicket win, leaving Axar Patel and Co. with a lot of soul-searching to do in the coming days.

Heightening the sense of



Wreckers-in-chief: Bhuvneshwar began the slide by cleaning up debutant Sahil while Hazlewood signalled the end of the DC innings by yorking Porel. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

disbelief about the evening was the fact that 529 runs had been scored for the loss of just six wickets across two innings on an adjacent pitch just 48 hours ago. Bhuvneshwar sparked the collapse. With debutant Sahil Parakh on strike in the opening over, the 36-year-old conjured

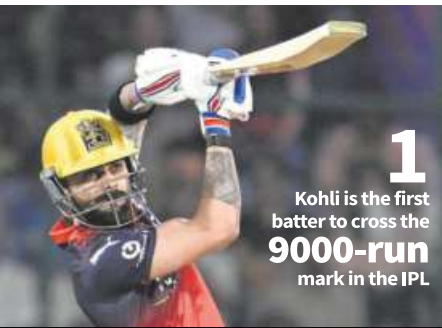
up an inswinging yorker to uproot middle stump. He would also account for Tristan Stubbs and Axar in the third over.

From the other end, Hazlewood was just as spell-binding. Off his first two balls, he dismissed K.L. Rahul and Sameer Rizvi. Rahul was hurried by a boun-

cer, miscuing a pull to wicketkeeper Jitesh Sharma. Rizvi was enticed into a loose drive to a ball wide of off-stump.

The others crumbled predictably like a pack of cards, with Hazlewood fittingly ending Capitals’ misery by cleaning up Porel with a yorker.

Impact Index



1 DC lost six wickets with less than 10 runs on the board, a first in the league

4 Sahil (18y 324d) is the fourth youngest opener to be dismissed for a duck (Suryavanshi 14y 35d; Mhatre 17y 295d; Jaiswal 18y 283d)

16 The number of deliveries DC took to lose its first five wickets. RR had lost half its side in 18 balls against SRH earlier this season

29 Bhuvneshwar’s tally of wickets in the opening over. Only Boult (32) has more

50 Hazlewood’s wicket of Rahul was the Australian’s 50th in RCB colours

129 The number of wicket-taking innings for Bhuvneshwar, behind only Chahal (132)

COMPILED BY ANIRUDH VELAMURI

SCOREBOARD

DELHI CAPITALS
Sahil Parakh b Bhuvneshwar 0 (2b), K.L. Rahul c Jitesh b Hazlewood 1 (3b), Nitish Rana c Padikkal b Hazlewood 1 (9b), Sameer Rizvi c Jitesh b Hazlewood 0 (1b), Tristan Stubbs c Padikkal b Bhuvneshwar 5 (3b, 1x4), Axar Patel c Jitesh b Bhuvneshwar 0 (3b), Abishek Porel (Impact Player for Parakh) b Hazlewood 30 (33b, 3x4), David Miller c Jitesh b Rasikh 19 (18b, 3x4), Kyle Jamieson lbw b Krunal 12 (13b, 1x4, 1x6), Kuldeep Yadav b Suyash 3 (11b), Dushmantha Chameera (not out) 0 (3b); Extras (w-4); 4; Total (in 16.3 overs): 75.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-0 (Sahil, 0.2 overs), 2-2 (Rahul, 1.1), 3-2 (Rizvi, 1.2), 4-7 (Stubbs, 2.1), 5-7 (Axar, 2.4), 6-8 (Nitish, 3.5), 7-43 (Miller, 8.6), 8-62 (Jamieson, 12.3), 9-71 (Kuldeep, 15.3).

RCB BOWLING
Bhuvneshwar 3-0-5-3, Hazlewood

3.3-0-12-4, Rasikh 2-0-21-1, Shepherd 2-0-21-0, Suyash 4-1-7-1, Krunal 2-0-9-1.

ROYAL CHALLENGERS
Jacob Bethell (Impact Player for Suyash) c Natarajan b Jamieson 20 (11b, 1x4, 2x6), Virat Kohli (not out) 23 (15b, 1x4, 2x6), Devdutt Padikkal (not out) 34 (13b, 3x4, 3x6); Total (for one wkt. in 6.3 overs): 77.

FALL OF WICKET
1-26 (Bethell, 2.5).

CAPITALS BOWLING
Jamieson 3-0-42-1, Chameera 2-0-18-0, Axar 1-0-5-0, Natarajan 0-3-0-12-0.

Toss: RCB; **PoM:** Hazlewood. RCB won by nine wickets with 81 balls to spare.

Next assignment

RCB: April 30 vs. GT Ahmedabad, 7.30 p.m.

DC: May 1 vs. RR Jaipur, 7.30 p.m.

We have to forget this day and move on: Axar

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

Delhi Capitals’ forlorn skipper Axar Patel wants his team to try and move on after it suffered a nine-wicket rout at the hands of Royal Challengers Bengaluru in IPL 2026 at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Monday.

On a warm evening where Bhuvneshwar Kumar and Josh Hazlewood caused mayhem under lights, DC was shot out for a paltry 75 in 16.3 overs. According to Axar, the run-fest at this venue just two days ago, when Punjab Kings chased down a record 265, may have had an effect on the host’s batters.

“What happened in the last game, when we lost after scoring 264, may have had an effect. There was hesitation from the batters. Other than that, it was bad luck. The batters just kept getting out within a few balls. We will just have to forget this day and move on,” Axar said at the post-match press conference. “Bhuvneshwar and Hazlewood are world-class bowlers who held a good length.”

With DC’s fans expressing their anger after an abject display, the 32-year-old



Axar greets Kohli after the game. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

pleaded for support for his players. “If the fans are disheartened, the players are just as disheartened. This is the time for the fans to support the team. The players are down. At this time, it is very important for the fans to lend their support and trust the players,” he stated.

Meanwhile, RCB, with six wins in eight games, is hitting the right notes. Asked if the defending champion is the hot favourite to go all the way, Krunal Pandya said: “You can’t think too far ahead in this tournament. There are six more games to go in the league stage. We want to just continue doing the right things more often than not, stick to the process and look to get the desired results”.



Business as usual: RCB star Kohli cracks a joke with Nitish Rana and Kuldeep after finishing off the chase. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Opening salvos in focus as PBKS hosts RR

Sahil Mathur
NEW CHANDIGARH

Yashasvi Jaiswal, Vaibhav Suryavanshi, Priyansh Arya, and Prabhsimran Singh – in any other era, at least two of them would’ve been opening for India in T20Is. Yet, none of them is currently.

But all eyes will be on these dashing openers when Punjab Kings hosts Rajasthan Royals in an IPL-19 clash at the Maharaja Yadavindra Singh Stadium here on Tuesday.

Jaiswal and Suryavanshi have struck at 192.45 while opening, just behind Priyansh and Prabhsimran’s 215.53 strike-rate. The two pairs have been monumental to their teams’ performances so far. While PBKS has been unbeaten in seven games, RR has won five out of eight.

Apart from these four, Cooper Connolly has done well to establish himself in his debut IPL season with PBKS. He’s followed by Shreyas Iyer, who has been

Today’s match

PUNJAB KINGS vs. RAJASTHAN ROYALS

New Chandigarh, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 30

PBKS 13 | RR 17

PREVIOUS MEETING

PBKS won by 10 runs, 2025

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIHOTSTAR

just as impressive. But beyond that, there’s inconsistency.

PBKS assistant coach Brad Haddin, however, feels that the lower-order batters haven’t had a lot of opportunities to face enough deliveries. “Our top-order has been super dynamic, and the rest have contributed in roles that win games. It might not be a 70 or 80, but maybe a 15 off six balls to give us the momentum we need. They’re doing everything



The job’s not done. We’re halfway through the tournament, and it’s about playing your best cricket at the back-end

BRAD HADDIN
PBKS assistant coach

the game requires.”

For Royals, the bowlers – led by Jofra Archer (13 wickets), Ravi Bishnoi (11), and Nandre Burger (8) – have compensated for the batting vulnerabilities in the lower middle-order.

“Our bowling unit has been doing well. The new-ball bowlers have been picking wickets consistently, and I’m confident they can keep delivering,” RR quick Sandeep Sharma said. On Tuesday, it will be a hitting contest between the openers. RR captain Parag would be hoping to get the toss right, utilise swing on offer and force PBKS to set a total, else things could go out of RR’s control.



Bowlers assemble: Royals pacer Sandeep and Kings leggie Chahal will be tasked with restricting the batters. R.V. MOORTHY

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Punjab Kings	7	6	0	1	13	1.333
Royal Challengers	8	6	2	0	12	1.919
Sunrisers Hyderabad	8	5	3	0	10	0.815
Rajasthan Royals	8	5	3	0	10	0.602
Gujarat Titans	8	4	4	0	8	-0.475
Chennai Super Kings	8	3	5	0	6	-0.121
Delhi Capitals	8	3	5	0	6	-1.060
Kolkata Knight Riders	8	2	5	1	5	-0.751
Mumbai Indians	7	2	5	0	4	-0.736
Lucknow Super Giants	8	2	6	0	4	-1.106

Indian men blank Australia, storm into the quarterfinals

THOMAS & UBER CUP

Press Trust of India
HORSENS (DENMARK)

India sealed a place in the Thomas Cup Finals quarterfinals with a 5-0 sweep of Australia in a Group A tie here on Monday.

India and China occupy the top spots in the group. The 2022 champion had opened with a 4-1 win over Canada, while China blanked Australia 5-0 and beat Canada 4-1 earlier in the day. The two sides will clash in their final group tie on Wednesday to decide the group topper.

Paris Olympian and Commonwealth Games champion Lakshya Sen set the tone with a 21-14, 21-16 win over Ephraim Stephen Sam. US Open champion Ayush Shetty, who recently finished runner-up at the Badminton Asia Championships, doubled the ad-



Easily done: Chirag and Satwik won in quick time. X@BAI_MEDIA

China takes lead

Wang Zhiyi beat P.V. Sindhu 21-16, 19-21, 21-19 to give China a 1-0 lead against India in the Uber Cup

vantage with a 21-8, 21-6 victory over Shrey Dhand.

The top pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, the Asian Games champions, made it 3-0 by defeating Rizky Hidayat and Jack Yu 21-14, 21-16 to clinch the tie.

H.S. Prannoy, a bronze medalist at the 2023 World Championships and Asian Games, extended the lead with a 21-11, 21-17 win over Rishi Honda Boo-

pathy in under 30 minutes.

In the second doubles, Hariharan Amsakarunan and M.R. Arjun outplayed Andika Ramadiansyah and Ephraim Stephen Sam 21-12, 21-10 as India completed a flawless outing.

The result: Thomas Cup:

India bt Australia 5-0 [Lakshya Sen bt Ephraim Stephen Sam 21-14, 21-16; Ayush Shetty bt Shrey Dhand 21-8, 21-6; Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty bt Rizky Hidayat & Jack Yu 21-14, 21-16; H.S. Prannoy bt Rishi Honda Boopathy 21-11, 21-17; Hariharan Amsakarunan & M.R. Arjun bt Andika Ramadiansyah & Ephraim Stephen Sam 21-12, 21-10].

INBRIEF



Sindhu gets a full voting position on the BWF council

P.V. Sindhu has assumed a full voting position on the council of the Badminton World Federation (BWF) following her election as chair of the BWF Athletes' Commission, according to a release. As a voting member of the council, Sindhu will participate in discussions and decisions on matters that shape the future of the sport.

Villarreal continues fine show; Milan, Juventus split points

Villarreal continued its strong season with a 2-1 victory over Celta Vigo to tighten the grip on third place in the LaLiga. AC Milan and Juventus played out a goalless draw in Serie A.

The results: LaLiga: Real Oviedo 1 (Chaira 76) lost to Elche 2 (Bigas 6, Villar 16); Osasuna 2 (Garcia 80, Catena 90+9) bt Sevilla 1 (Maupay 69); Villarreal 2 (Moreno 2-pen, Pepe 29) bt Celta Vigo 1 (Iglesias 73-pen).
Serie A: AC Milan 0 drew with Juventus 0.

Delhi HC allows AITA's 2024 poll results to stand

The Delhi High Court on Monday allowed the results of the All India Tennis Association (AITA) elections, held on September 28, 2024, to stand, but directed that the elected body will function only as an interim arrangement under the supervision of a court-appointed Administrator, former Chief Justice Gita Mittal.



Hridoy helps Bangladesh beat NZ

Associated Press
CHATTOGRAM

Tawhid Hridoy's half-century led Bangladesh to a six-wicket win over New Zealand in the first T20I in Chattogram on Monday. Hridoy finished unbeaten on 51 (27b, 4x4, 3x6).

The scores: New Zealand 182/6 in 20 overs (Clarke 51, Cleaver 51, Kelly 39, Rishad 2/32) lost to Bangladesh 183/4 in 18 overs (Hridoy 51 n.o., Shamim 31 n.o., Sodhi 2/40).
Toss: Bangladesh; **PoM:** Hridoy.

MRC-A makes the final despite centuries from Guru, Dhiyash

FIRST DIVISION

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

Centuries from S. Guru Raghavendran (126, 267b, 13x4, 2x6) and A.B. Dhiyash (101, 256b, 11x4, 3x6) weren't enough as MRC-A took a slender first-innings lead against Globe Trotters and entered the final, on the third day of Qualifier-1 in the TNCA first division league playoffs at Gojan-A on Monday.

In reply to MRC-A's 400, Trotters was bowled out for 385. Guru and Dhiyash added 96 for the fifth wicket, with the latter bringing up his maiden first division century. Guru also shared a 104-run sixth-wicket stand with left-hander B. Pranav (57). Medium-pacer P. Saravana Kumar claimed five for 81 – his second five-



Guru (Globe Trotters, 126); Dhiyash (Globe Trotters, 101); Saravana (MRC-A, 5/81).

MRC-A enters the final on first innings lead
Rovers to face Trotters in Qualifier-2 from May 1 to 3

wicket haul of the season – as MRC-A secured a crucial 15-run first-innings lead to progress.

Rovers in Qualifier-2

In the Eliminator, Jolly Rovers advanced to Qualifier-2 after gaining a 79-run first-innings lead over Nelson SC at Gojan-B.

Robin Bist top-scored with 96 (172b, 9x4, 1x6) for Nelson, while off-spinner

Selection blunders and a lack of clarity hurting CSK

The five-time champion has, in the past, been reluctant to chop and change the personnel; the host bringing in Sarfaraz as an Impact Player against GT was the latest in a series of baffling calls

IPL-19

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

Over the years, one of the key tenets of Stephen Fleming's coaching style at Chennai Super Kings has been what he likes to call 'consistency in selection.'

The five-time champion has, in the past, been reluctant to chop and change players, even when they were going through a rough patch, preferring to give them a long rope and getting the best out of them.

However, this season, CSK's selection policy has been inconsistent and deviated from its own method. Sunday's loss to Gujarat Titans exposed how the Super Kings brain trust has made a hash of it. Buoyant after the 103-run win over Mumbai Indians, there was no need to tinker with the line-up.

Instead, the host decided to drop Sarfaraz Khan in favour of Urvil Patel. It might have been a 50-50 call, but what transpired in the fourth over after losing two quick wickets was perplexing. CSK brought in



In the doldrums: CSK faces the threat of failing to qualify for the playoffs for a third straight year. R. RAGU

Sarfaraz as Impact Player, shutting the door on a bowling option for the second half.

This was the latest in a series of baffling decisions. Jamie Overton, the silver lining in the abject surrender to Rajasthan Royals in Super Kings' first match of the season, was dropped for the second game. The Englishman has, however, now cemented his spot and been one of the top performers. Curiously, Prashant Veer, who made a quickfire 43 against Royal

Challengers Bengaluru during the pursuit of a mammoth target of 251, hasn't emerged from the dugout again.

CSK lost its first three games before winning two on the bounce at home. Left-arm spinner Akeal Hosen added teeth to a thin bowling attack and was one of the architects of the mini revival. But, in the match against Sunrisers Hyderabad, the West Indian was dropped because the opponent had three left-handed batters in the

top-order! And Ruturaj's men went on to lose the game.

Akeal returned with a bang, producing a match-winning spell of four for 17 against MI.

After a fifth reverse in eight matches, CSK faces the threat of exiting before the playoffs for a third straight year. If that happens, the selection blunders will come under scrutiny. It's time the think-tank follows the simple philosophy: if it ain't broke, don't fix it.

Ham thrilled to be playing at The Open



Making the grade: Ham and John are all smiles after getting an entry to The Open Championship. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

GOLF

S. Shrivathsan
SINGAPORE

Jeongwoo Ham was a largely unknown commodity outside South Korea before he teed off at the Singapore Open, but the 31-year-old left the Sentosa shores only after making a mark with his maiden title on the Asian Tour.

There was double delight for Ham as the first-place finish in the International Series tournament also earned him a spot, along with second-placed Cameron John, at The Open Championship.

"Watching Korean and other Asian players at The Open... it was something that I could only be envious of. I did not expect the dream to turn into reality. The Open will be a new experience for me. I will go there to have a lot of fun,"

said Ham, who was competing in an Asian Tour event outside Korea for only the eighth time.

The crown was a fruit of the remarkable consistency that Ham showed over the four days.

"In the last two years, I have not been playing too well, so this victory will act as a motivation for me. It tells me that if I prepare well, I can win tournaments. I am proud that I have shown improvement with this win,"he added.

Having come out of his comfort zone and climbed the ladder, Ham is now keen on putting on a show at home as well. "I have already won once (this year), so I want to play in Korea in front of our fans and win there too. I will just ride with the tide."

Ham may have just found his second wind. (The writer is in Singapore at the invitation of The International Series)

Vaishali to play in WR Women's Chess Tour

Sports Bureau

R. Vaishali will play in the inaugural edition of the newly launched WR Women's Chess Tour, to be held in Tokyo on June 6 and 7.

Big names

The tour, which aims to raise the profile of women's chess and position in global events like the WTA, will feature big names.

Vaishali, who recently won the Candidates tournament in Cyprus, to become the challenger for the World title match, and former World champions Alexandra Kosteniuk and Antoaneta Stefanova are among the first players to be confirmed for the tour.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: Friends inter-academy u-12 tournament, 1 p.m., N.M. Greens.

India loses final T20I as SA wraps up series 4-1

INDIA IN SA

Press Trust of India
BENONI

India suffered yet another batting meltdown in a modest 156-run chase as South Africa rode on skipper Laura Wolvaardt's sublime unbeaten 92 (56b, 11x4, 2x6) to clinch a convincing 23-run win and seal the T20I series 4-1 in dominant fashion.

Wolvaardt, who had already notched up two fifties and a century in the series, struck 11 fours and two sixes in her 56-ball knock, carrying her bat despite wickets falling around her.

Late flourish

Her late flourish – two sixes off the final two balls – lifted South Africa past the 150-mark after a middle-overs slowdown.

In reply, India was restricted to 132 for eight, with the experienced batters once again failing to deliver.

Skipper Harmanpreet Kaur laboured to 22 off 28 balls, while Shafali Verma (4), Jemimah Rodrigues (1) and Deepti Sharma (8) fell cheaply without much resistance.

It was left to Bharti Fulmali to provide some fight with a counter-attacking 40 off 30 balls (4x4, 2x6), but India's middle-overs stagnation following a poor



Wolvaardt. X@PROTEASWOMENCSA

start proved costly.

South Africa's bowlers were disciplined throughout, with Nonkululeko Mlaba leading the charge with an impressive two for 15, including a maiden, and accounting for Harmanpreet.

Nadine de Klerk also took two wickets.

Reality check

It was a reality check for the Women's ODI champions India ahead of the T20 World Cup in two months' time, as frequent changes in the XI and lack of consistency hurt the campaign.

The scores: South Africa 155/6 in 20 overs (Wolvaardt 92 n.o., Deepti 2/37) bt India 132/8 in 20 overs (Bharti 40, de Klerk 2/26).

Toss: SA.
PoM & Pos: Wolvaardt.

SNAPSHOTS

Mirabai likely to miss Asian championships

KOLKATA: Weightlifter Mirabai Chanu is set to miss the Asian championships in Gandhinagar from May 12 to 17 due to a shoulder issue, according to reliable sources. Mirabai had picked up the shoulder issue during the Nationals at Modinagar earlier this year.

Tapan, Harschit are all-around champions

BHUBANESWAR: Tapan Mohanty and Harschit Damodaran won the men's senior and junior all-around gold respectively in the National artistic gymnastics. **The results: Men: Senior: Individual: All-around:** 1. Tapan Mohanty (Odisha) 73.433, 2. Yogeshwar Singh (Haryana) 72.667, 3. Shreyas Chaudhari (SSCB) 71.467. **Team:** 1. Railways 220.533, 2. Services 211.767, 3. Maharashtra 211.303. **Junior: Individual: All-around:** 1. Harschit Damodaran (UP) 73.700, 2. Akshat Bajaj (Delhi) 69.866, 3. Sk. Nabigh Ali (WB) 69.767.

YMCA Nandanam-A wins title

CHENNAI: YMCA Nandanam-A won the C-Zone title in the 33rd Sanmar TNTA Chennai City Club league championship, beating Gandhi Nagar Club-B 2-1 in the final. Anna Nagar K Block-C won the F-Zone crown with a 3-0 win over Indira Nagar SC-C. **The results: Finals: C-Zone: YMCA Nandanam-A bt Gandhi Nagar Club-B** 2-1 (Bhusan Babu & S. Anand bt V. Nishant & Naren 6-0, 6-1; V. Ashwin & Mehul Jothish bt Shivakumar Viswanathan & Srish Venkat 6-2, 6-2; Siddarth Bommanan & Siddharth Dinesh lost to Ashwin Venkataraman & Chirag 7-6(9), 2-6, 4-6). **F-Zone: Anna Nagar K Block-C bt Indira Nagar SC-C** 3-0 (Sreeshan Parameswaran & Tarun Hari bt Vikram Chandiramani & Raj Chordia 6-4, 6-2; Karthick Iyemperumal & Karthikeyan Natham bt V.N. Saravanan & Abdul Rahamon 6-2, 6-0; Goutham Kumar & M.V. Aditya bt R. Madhavan & Kedhar Rajagopalan 6-3, 6-3).

Pattabiram CA in final Medium-pacer Rashul



Triumphant: YMCA Nandanam-A team members Siddarth, Anand, Ashwin, Laxman, Vijayakumar, Bhusan, Siddharth, and Mehul. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Victorious: Anna Nagar K Block-C team members Karthick, Sreeshan, Tarun, Aditya, Goutham, Karthikeyan, Aswin, Pratheesh, and Vignesh. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Thendral (CPCL, 4/26, incl. hat-trick); Haseef (Pattabiram CA, 5/19); Praveen (Lucas TVS, 5/24).

Haseef claimed five for 19 as Pattabiram CA defeated CPCL RC by 40 runs in Qualifier-1 of the Thiruvallur DCA third division league playoffs. V. Thendral's impressive hat-trick haul (four for 26) went in vain.

The scores: Playoffs: II div.: Qualifier-1: SRIHER 147 in 30 overs (M. Gireeshwar 31, R. Sanjai Sooriya 4/19, R.S. Sujith 3/32) lost to Mogappair 148/3 in 23.1 overs (M. Vishal 88 n.o.). **Eliminator:** Universal 160/8 in 30 overs (P. Ajay 42, S. Rajeshkumar 31, J. Senthil 30 n.o., K. Nirmal Kumar 4/30) lost to Aththis 161/7 in 27.4 overs (R. Martin Anburaj 81, S. Sathyananth 38 n.o.).

III div.: Qualifier-1: Pattabiram 186/9 in 30 overs (M. Vinit Kumar 85, K. Raja Pratap 35, V. Thendral 4/26) bt CPCL 146 in 28.4 overs (N. Mohamed Yusuff 47, N. Rashul Haseef 5/19). **Eliminator:** Parthasarathy MCC 143 in 29.4 overs (S. Stephen Raj

50, Chetan Kumar Meena 3/25, K. Sudhakar 3/16) lost to Sunder 144/3 in 26.4 overs (K. Sudhakar 30, D. Hithesh 50 n.o.).

Praveen scalps five

Medium-pacer G. Praveen Kumar's five for 24 set up a 10-wicket win for Lucas TVS over IJL in a Group-B match of the 21st Lucas TVS TDCA Trophy.

The scores: Group-B: IJL 62 in 17.5 overs (G. Praveen Kumar 5/24) lost to Lucas TVS 67 for no loss in 3.5 overs (U. Vinoth Kannan 51 n.o.).

LIVE TELECAST

IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m.

ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & Fan-Code, 7.30 p.m.

Champions League: Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 12.30 a.m. (Wednesday)

Kohli, Rahul and the journey to T20 greatness

In the last three years, the RCB talisman has taken his game in the shortest format to a new level and remains a great role model in modern sport; he is also the benchmark for the Capitals' keeper-batter and the new generation



K. MURALI KUMAR & R.V. MOORTHY

R. Kaushik

Within three years of one Rahul from Karnataka calling time on a career most illustrious, another Rahul from the same state cut his teeth in international cricket. In the same country where Rahul Dravid played his final game for the country, KL Rahul made his Test debut - not a very auspicious one - in what turned out to be Mahendra Singh Dhoni's final five-day appearance.

Batting out of position at the Melbourne Cricket Ground in December 2014, the younger Rahul managed 3 in the first innings (at No. 6) and 1 in the second, when he was pushed up to No. 3. In the next game in Sydney, in Virat Kohli's first Test as full-time captain, Rahul celebrated his elevation to the opener's slot, which was where he always belonged, with a measured 110 which spanned just under six hours.

With two further hundreds in his next eight innings, both overseas - in Colombo against Sri Lanka (August 2015) and in Kingston against West Indies (July 2016) - Rahul seemed to be the answer to India's quest for a dependable, reliable Test opener. Either side of the Kingston hundred, he racked his maiden tons in One-Day Internationals (on debut) and Twenty20 Internationals (in his fourth innings) to complete the full set - international centuries in all three formats - in double quick time, becoming the fastest Indian to that milestone.

When he made an unbeaten 110 in August 2016 against West Indies in Lauderhill in a T20I to round off the troika, Rahul was only 24. The world was at his feet, it appeared, but there has been nothing straightforward about his journey thereafter.

Change of fortunes

Blighted by untimely injuries and inexplicable losses of form, Rahul's career meandered along rather than hitting the high notes it promised from the off. There was a certain exasperating consistency to his inconsistency. He possessed everything - exceptional technique, all the strokes in the book, a languid elegance that makes him such an arresting figure at the batting crease - but often seemed his worst enemy, weighed down by an inner burden that threatened to be his kryptonite.

Successive leadership groups invested heavily in him, but in both Test and T20 cricket, he seemed determined to sell himself short.

The story was different in the 50-over format where he found his calling - not like the senior Rahul - as a wicketkeeper-batter that could control the middle overs with felicity. Like his

namesake from the same city, 'KL' refamiliarised himself with the role he had reprised in his school days and graduated beyond being a 'part-time' stumper, playing influential roles in India's march to final of the home World Cup in 2023 and to the Champions Trophy title in Dubai in March 2025.

By this time, Rahul had lost his place in the T20I set-up, and with good reason. An underwhelming run at the 2022 World Cup in Australia proved his undoing, but Rahul was on the way to resurrecting his Test career. He had had a middling tour of Australia with half-centuries in the victory in Perth and the draw in Brisbane, though in a sequence emblematic of his career at the time, he ended the tour with scores of 24, 0, 4 and 13.

Within a few weeks of the Champions Trophy triumph, Rohit Sharma pulled the plug on his Test career, and Rahul was pencilled into partner Yashasvi Jaiswal for the foreseeable future. His successes in England, where he made hundreds in losing causes in Leeds and at Lord's, apart from an obdurate 90 in a match-saving cause in Manchester, were attributed to job security, if you like, but by then, Rahul had found an inner calm and a greater purpose in life that magically lifted the weight he had been carrying and freed him up mentally.

Working wonders

Fatherhood clearly has worked wonders; in March last year, he and wife Athiya were blessed with a baby girl. Cricket was no longer the be-all and end-all. His passion for the sport continued to burn bright, make no mistake, but he became more 'chill' about the game, no longer consumed by it even though he was driven enough to become the best version of himself.

The mental shift has manifested itself in Rahul 2.0, now bearing no resemblance to the ponderous young man whose dimpled smiles had become rare as hen's teeth. Beyond fatherhood, other factors have assisted in the transformation, including the realisation that he had remained stagnant as the world sped by him. The truly excellent ones are those whose best allies are introspection and brutal self-appraisal. Rahul went to the mental drawing board, identified where he needed to get better at, and here we are, Circa 2026, with KL Rahul as the owner of the highest score by an Indian in all T20s.

His monumental unbeaten 152 the other afternoon for Delhi Capitals against Punjab Kings in the sweltering heat of the national capital was the ultimate affirmation of Rahul's development as a 20-over batter. It was also evidence of the work he had put in behind the scenes to stay in touch with the modern tenets of

the T20 game, where innings-building is a strict no-no and where maximising the PowerPlay has become paramount though looking at some of the batters, one would think that the field restrictions apply throughout the length of the 20 overs. Rahul matched and topped the 42-degree heat with 16 fours and nine sixes off 67 deliveries, lighting up the Arun Jaitley Stadium with his incandescence, correctness and fluency. "It's something I've been working on for a very long time behind the scenes... to just to step back a little back and see where the T20 game has gone," he admitted.

Mental set-up

"Watching the T20 World Cup and some guys coming in... There was a time when the T20 game was slightly different, and I, as an opener, could take my time. But today's demand is that the first six overs are the most important. I had to sit back and see where I was at. I stuck to being true to my game. In T20 cricket, that's the mindset I'm in right now - that there's no time to say later. There's no time to think you can go next over. I've had to work really hard on my mental set-up."

Last year, Rahul spoke of the mental work he had done in Salzburg in Austria, the headquarters of Red Bull with whom he is associated. "I have spent a bit of time with an expert who can help me with improving my reaction time and some mental drills and games that you can play that help you get better with your reaction time," he had revealed. "I had the opportunity to work with some of the coaches that work with the elite Formula One guys and other adventure sports people who require a lot of this mental side of the game." That testifies to the hunger, if not the desperation, to keep getting better, a trait that is second nature to one of the greats of the game who is now on the last but still strong and steady legs of a career most extraordinary.

Rich cabinet

There are very few highs that Kohli hasn't experienced. He has been part of World Cup-winning sides in both the 50-over and T20 formats, crowning the latter with the Player-of-the-Final performance in his last 20-over fixture for the country. He has been in more than one Champions Trophy-winning side, oversaw the transformation of Indian cricket with his emphasis on fast bowling and uncompromising fitness standards and ensured that his colleagues treated every Test match, especially, as a home Test by refusing to dwell on pitches.

His contribution to the sport in the country and beyond is unquantifiable. He now plays only one format internationally, potentially with an eye on the 50-over World Cup in the Africas late

next year, but he isn't just biding time or looking to rest on bountiful past laurels.

Kohli finished his international T20 career with impressive numbers - 4,188 runs, average 48.69, strike-rate 137.04. There were some question marks over the last figure, but Kohli played much of his 20-over cricket for the country when team totals of 200 weren't anywhere near the norm and there was a more conservative approach to the format. In the IPL, his strike-rate hovered around the last 120s, not flash by any stretch of the imagination. Indeed, until the start of the 2024 edition, he struck at more than 150 runs for 100 balls faced just once in 16 seasons - in 2016 when he amassed a staggering 973 runs with four centuries (SR 152.03).

But in the last three years, he has taken his T20 game to a whole new level, and that is saying something. Just a few days before the start of the T20 World Cup in 2024, he upped his strike rate in the IPL to 154.70; last season, it stood at 144.71 and this year, ahead of Monday's showdown against Delhi Capitals, the former Royal Challengers Bengaluru captain boasted 163.18 at an average of 81, remarkable considering that he is a very young 37.

Kohli is the benchmark for Rahul, and for generations thereafter - for the likes of Abhishek Sharma and Ishan Kishan and Prabhsimran Singh and Priyansh Arya, and the dynamic Rajasthan Royals duo of Jaiswal and the ridiculously prodigious 15-year-old, Vaibhav Suryavanshi.

Intensity and hunger

That, this late in his career, Kohli has not just felt the need but found the magic to up the ante is credit to his intensity and hunger, to the high standards he sets for himself, for the desire to prove to himself more than anyone else that he doesn't just belong to the T20 landscape, he can still be the master even as much younger protagonists are snapping at his heels.

Kohli has seldom tried to meet the expectations of others. No one is harsher on himself, and his sustained commitment to fitness and discipline when it comes to diet and looking after his body are beyond enviable.

That, this late in his career, Kohli has not just felt the need but found the magic to up the ante is credit to his intensity and hunger, to the high standards he sets for himself, for the desire to prove to himself more than anyone else that he doesn't just belong to the T20 landscape, he can still be the master even as much younger protagonists are snapping at his heels.

THE GIST

- ▼ Blighted by untimely injuries and inexplicable losses of form, Rahul's career meandered along rather than hitting the high notes it promised from the off
- ▼ The monumental unbeaten 152 for Delhi Capitals against Punjab Kings in the sweltering heat of the national capital was the ultimate affirmation of Rahul's development as a 20-over batter
- ▼ Kohli has seldom tried to meet the expectations of others. No one is harsher on himself, and his sustained commitment to fitness and discipline when it comes to diet and looking after his body are beyond enviable

CAR-T cell therapy senses ‘faint’ targets to clear solid tumours

Scientists have developed a highly sensitive receptor that can detect trace amounts of proteins on solid tumours, overcoming a major biological hurdle to using CAR T-cell therapy against cancers such as kidney or ovarian cancer; this can help eliminate previously undetectable tumour cells

Anirban Mukhopadhyay

Chimeric antigen receptor (CAR) T-cell therapy, an approach that modifies a patient's own immune cells to hunt down cancer, has transformed treatment for blood cancers such as leukaemia and lymphoma. But the same strategy has struggled when applied to solid tumours such as kidney or ovarian cancer.

One of the biggest obstacles is antigen heterogeneity. Tumours are not made of identical cells. Instead, they resemble a patchwork: some cells display the protein that CART cells detect while others appear to lack it. CAR-T cells only destroy ‘visible’ targets, so the invisible cells survive and allow the cancer to grow back.

Now, a study published in *Science* on February 26 has suggested these supposedly invisible cells may not be invisible after all. Many tumour cells thought to lack the target protein actually carry small amounts – too little for current CAR-T cells to detect.

The hidden protein

The study conducted by researchers in Columbia University and the Sloan Kettering Cancer Centre in New York focused on a protein called CD70. It is expressed by the tumours in about 70-80% of kidney and ovarian cancers and roughly a quarter of pancreatic cancers, making it an attractive target for immune therapy.

But in real world scenarios, some cells carry large quantities of CD70 while others appear negative in standard laboratory tests.

The researchers suspected that these negative cells might still produce small amounts of the protein.

To check this, they examined individual tumour cells and studied how the gene for CD70 was being regulated. They discovered that it was being suppressed by an enzyme called EZH2, which chemically modifies proteins around DNA.

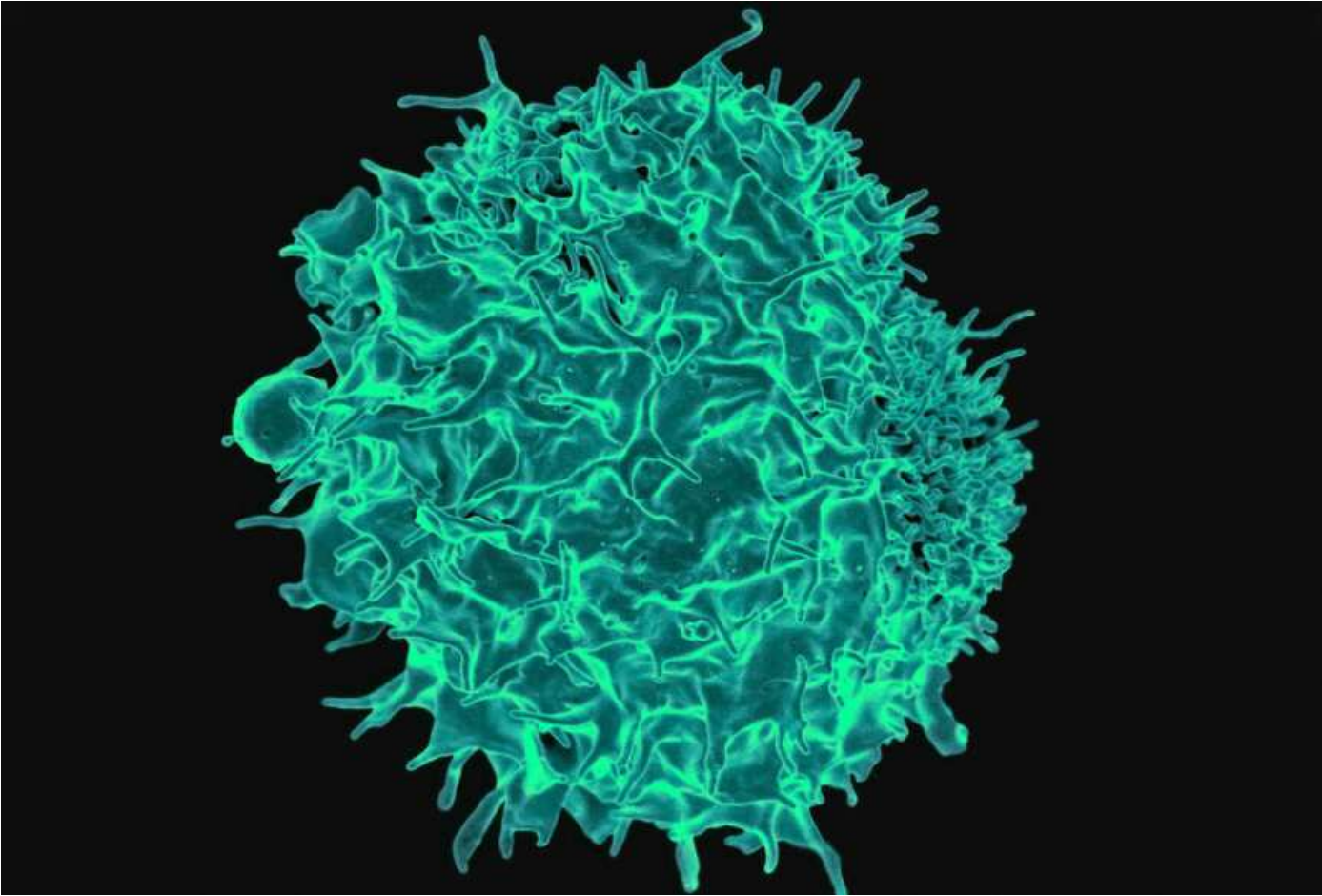
These modifications tighten the DNA structure, making it difficult for the cell to read the gene and reducing CD70 production to very low levels. This effectively dimmed the signal, making the cells undetectable to current immune therapies.

Detailed imaging in two kidney cancer models found more than 80-90% of tumour cells that appeared CD70-negative by conventional tests still carried detectable amounts of the protein.

Scott Lowe, a cancer biologist at the Sloan Kettering Institute, said tumours may keep these tiny amounts of the protein because they still need it to survive. “If the cancer cells need some of the protein to stay viable, there may be evolutionary pressure to keep it at very low levels rather than lose it completely,” he said.

The researchers called this phenomenon ‘pseudo-heterogeneity’ – the target protein is present in nearly all tumour cells but sometimes at levels too low for detection.

If cancer cells hide the target rather than eliminate it, the solution may be to



In CAR T-cell therapy, a patient's T cells (one shown) are isolated, engineered to target specific cancer cells, then reinfused to mount their attack. NIAID/UNSPLASH

build immune cells that detect faint signals.

Making T-cells more sensitive

To do this, the researchers developed a new receptor design called an HLA-independent T-cell (HIT) receptor.

Traditional CAR-T cells use receptors with molecular components that tell the immune cell when to attack. These triggers usually require a strong signal, meaning many copies of the target protein must be present on a cancer cell to elicit a response from T-cells.

The HIT receptor takes a different approach. Instead of changing the strength of the signal, it connects the cancer-detecting sensor directly to the T-cell's natural activation pathway – the internal system T-cells normally use to recognise infected cells – while bypassing the HLA system, the genetic ID tag that T-cells usually require to identify a target.

By co-opting this natural machinery, the receptor becomes able to detect antigens at much lower densities than a synthetic CAR.

A cancer biologist who peer-reviewed the study for the journal said anonymously that the finding could change how CAR-T therapies are designed: “If this principle holds for other tumour targets, it could change how we design CAR-T therapies. Instead of searching for perfectly uniform targets, we may need receptors that can detect very low levels of antigen.”

Testing the idea

The team tested the approach using xenograft models, in which real human tumour tissue is implanted in mice. These models closely mimic the complexity of cancers found in patients.



If the cancer cells need some of the protein to stay viable, there may be evolutionary pressure to keep it at very low levels rather than lose it completely.

SCOTT LOWE
Cancer biologist at the Sloan Kettering Institute

In kidney cancer models, conventional CAR-T cells initially shrank tumours but eventually failed. The remaining cancer cells, those with extremely low CD70 levels, survived and allowed the tumour to grow back.

The T-cells with the HIT receptor however eliminated these previously undetectable tumour cells. The researchers also observed complete and lasting tumour eradication in several models of kidney, ovarian, and pancreatic cancer with these T-cells.

Power versus safety

Increasing sensitivity raised one concern, however: “When you make immune cells better at detecting weak signals, you also have to be careful they don't start reacting to normal cells that carry small amounts of the same protein,” the researcher quoted earlier said.

This problem is often called the “Goldilocks challenge” of cell therapy. To evaluate this risk, the researchers analysed a large single-cell atlas of 30 human tissues and 222 different cell types, finding that CD70 activity was largely absent from most vital organs such as the heart, lungs, and brain.

A significant exception was activated immune cells, which naturally express

CD70 during immune responses. But even in those tissues, the protein appeared only in a small fraction of cells, typically less than 5%.

In experimental models, the engineered T-cells did attack some activated immune cells but the researchers called the effects temporary and manageable.

The biologist noted that future therapies will have to include additional safeguards: “If these treatments move into patients, researchers will likely add safety systems such as molecular switches so doctors can turn the cells off if necessary.”

A new hope

Professor Lowe said the finding fits a broader pattern cancer biologists have been observing for years.

There is strong evidence that changes in how genes are turned on or off in cancer cells (without changing the DNA itself) can help tumour cells survive targeted therapies, he said. “These cells, often called drug-tolerant persisters, can tolerate treatment and later allow the tumour to regrow.”

The researcher quoted earlier has tempered expectations for now. “It is still a long way from bedside application but if this strategy works in clinical trials, it could help tackle the biggest hurdle in cancer immunotherapy,” he said.

As he suggested, for patients with kidney or ovarian tumours, where treatment options are still limited, being able to uncover and eliminate these hidden cells could make a real difference.

(Anirban Mukhopadhyay is a geneticist by training and science communicator from New Delhi. anirban.genetics@south.du.ac.in)



The Paranal Observatory operated by European Southern Observatory stands in the Atacama Desert, Chile, April 14, 2026. AP

Light pollution threatens the world's clearest skies

Associated Press

It takes a moment for the eyes to adjust. A faint spark appears in the darkness; then another, brighter one. Soon, stars, planets and entire constellations emerge. Before long, a whole galaxy stretches across the sky, visible to the naked eye.

In Chile's Atacama Desert, the night sky feels infinite. Considered the driest place on the earth, its darkness is also one of the clearest windows to the universe.

A rare combination of dry climate, high altitude, and isolation from urban light pollution makes the Atacama an unrivalled hub for world-class astronomy and home to the world's largest ground-based astronomical projects.

“The conditions in the Atacama Desert are unique in the world,” said Chiara Mazzucchelli, president of the Chilean Astronomical Society. “There are more than 300 clear nights per year, meaning no clouds and no rain.”

But these skies may be at risk.

A rare combination of dry climate, high altitude, and isolation from light pollution makes the Atacama a hub for astronomy and home to some of the largest astronomical projects

Last year, the desert became a battleground between scientists and an energy firm proposing a green power complex just kilometres from the Paranal Observatory. Managed by the European Southern Observatory (ESO), the site also is the future home to what is to be the most powerful optical telescope.

Although the energy project was cancelled in January following an appeal from astronomers and physicists, it exposed concerns that existing sky preservation laws are outdated and unclear. Since then, several environmental regulations have come under review.

The so-called Photon Valley in Chile is a high-altitude corridor where several observatories operate side by side using some of the most sophisticated instruments ever engineered.

“ESO's telescopes in particular are the most powerful astronomical facilities on the planet,” said Itziar de Gregorio-Monsalvo, the ESO representative in Chile.

Every year, the Atacama Desert draws thousands of astronomers and scientists from around the world. “We are lucky to be here,” said Julia Bodensteiner, an assistant professor at University of Amsterdam.

Walking across the Atacama's rocky, uneven terrain is no easy task. At altitudes exceeding 3,000 m, oxygen becomes a luxury, while scorching days give way to relentlessly cold nights. But for space observation, the more than 105,000 sq. km of desert are the perfect setting.

The exceptional conditions of the Atacama have enabled some of the most ambitious astronomical projects ever conceived, like the Extremely Large Telescope, ELT – a \$1.5 billion endeavor by ESO scheduled for completion in 2030.

With 798 mirrors and a light-gathering area of nearly 1,000 square metres, the ELT will be 20 times more powerful than today's leading telescopes and 15-times sharper than Hubble Space Telescope.

Twenty years ago, the Atacama Desert was “an ocean of darkness,” recalled Eduardo Unda-Sanzana, director of the Astronomy Center at the University of Antofagasta.

Over the years, however, the landscape has changed drastically. Driven by urban sprawl, industrial development, and the arrival of mining and wind farms, the desert has become coveted territory where balance is not always easy to reach.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Explorers who undertook ‘impossible’ expeditions

Vasudevan Mukunth

- QUESTION 1
- Name the first person to summit all 14 eight-thousanders: peaks of the world higher than 8,000 m. He was also the first person to climb Mt Everest solo and the first person along with Peter Habeler to climb it without supplemental oxygen. He also crossed Antarctica and Greenland sans sleds or mobiles.
- QUESTION 2
- _____ was the first Western woman (of British-Italian descent) to travel through the Hadhramaut valley of Yemen and mapped previously uncharted territories of Persia and West Asia, often alone and on minimal resources. Fill in the blanks.
- QUESTION 3
- Trained by the British Survey of India, X mapped Tibet, Lhasa, and a large

- section of the Brahmaputra while travelling in disguise. He covered some of the highest, most forbidden terrain on the earth and walked for more than 2,500 km. Name X.
- QUESTION 4
- In the 10th century, the Abbasid Caliphate sent _____ on a diplomatic mission to the Volga Bulgars in 921-22. He travelled from Baghdad through Persia and Central Asia and produced the principal historical source on Viking funerary rites. Fill in the blanks.
- QUESTION 5
- In 1984, Y became the first Indian woman to summit Mt Everest, at the age of 30, and later led the first all-women traverse of the entire Himalayan and Karakoram range, a journey of 4,000 km over seven months through some of the world's most extreme terrain. Name Y.



VISUAL: Name this Norwegian adventurer, who set out on April 28, 1947, on the infamous Kon-Tiki expedition, since considered to be racially motivated, to the Polynesian islands. PUBLIC DOMAIN

Answers to April 21 quiz:

- City whose name in Arabic means “elephant's trunk” – **Ans: Khartoum**
 - Largest non-island city inaccessible by road – **Ans: Iquitos**
 - City where the Niger river reaches its northernmost arc – **Ans: Timbuktu**
 - City standing where the Negro and Amazon rivers converge – **Ans: Manaus**
 - City where ‘its’ river bends north, inhabited since 1200 BC – **Ans: Varanasi**
- Visual:** Chongqing
- First contact: K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Prem Nath Tiwari | Sunny Kumar | Sumit Raju

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Death toll in eastern Chad during clashes over water resources

42 A clash in eastern Chad between two families over a water point escalated into a cycle of reprisals, the country's Deputy Prime Minister said late Sunday. Limane Mahamat speaking during a visit to the village of Igote, in the Wadi Fira province, near the border with Sudan, where the clashes occurred on Saturday, said that 42 people were killed and 10 wounded. PTI

Seats secured by ZPM in Aizawl Municipal Corporation polls

17 The ruling Zoram People's Movement (ZPM) on Monday secured a landslide victory in the Aizawl Municipal Corporation polls, bagging 17 seats in the 19-member civic body in Mizoram. The main opposition Mizo National Front (MNF), which had won the previous election in 2021, had to settle with only one ward this time, while the Congress also bagged a seat. PTI

Total seizures of illicit inducements in Bengal during ongoing polls

510 in ₹ crore. The seizures are higher than the recoveries recorded during the last Assembly polls in 2021 which totalled ₹339 crore, as well as the 2024 Lok Sabha polls in the State. The recoveries include ₹30 crore in cash, over 48,000 litres of liquor worth ₹126.85 crore, drugs worth ₹110.12 crore and precious metals worth ₹58.28 crore. PTI

Increase in power demand in India, amid a heatwave this year

270 in GW. India ramped up coal and gas-fired power generation as peak demand increased. Peak power demand rose to a record 256.1 GW on April 25, federal grid data showed. India is likely to rely more on coal and has deferred maintenance of nearly 10,000 MW of coal-fired capacity. It expects peak demand to reach around 270 GW this year. REUTERS

Number of new districts notified in Ladakh by LG Saxena

5 Ladakh's Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Monday approved the creation of five new districts in the Union Territory, fulfilling the long-pending demand of the people of the region. Mr. Saxena said that with the creation of five new districts — Nubra, Sham, Changthang, Zaskar and Drass, Ladakh will now have seven districts. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Legal limits on U.S. war involvement

The War Powers Act requires the President to seek authorisation from Congress for the continued use of military force abroad beyond 60 days of such involvement, raising questions over the Trump administration's future course of action in the ongoing military engagement in West Asia

EXPLAINER

Narayan Lakshman

The story so far:

The administration of U.S. President Donald Trump launched a military offensive against Iran on February 28, in tandem with Israeli strikes across the region. Tehran's retaliation, entailing missile and drone attacks on Israel and Gulf countries such as the UAE, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and others, as well as its blockade of the critical oil transportation route through the Strait of Hormuz, led Washington deeper into the military engagement against Iran. Despite a fragile ceasefire and the U.S.'s counter-blockade of the Iranian ports and naval manoeuvres giving it a measure of control of the strait, the overall war plans of the Trump administration might be in jeopardy due to a provision of the U.S. constitution - the War Powers Act (WPA). The Act requires the President to seek authorisation from Congress for the continued use of military force in hostilities abroad beyond 60 days of such involvement, yet going by past record, Mr. Trump may have several options to circumvent this requirement and persist with the ongoing military engagement in West Asia.

Provisions of the WPA

The Act, known formally as the War Powers Resolution of 1973, was introduced into U.S. law in the context of President Richard Nixon's support for clandestine hostilities in Cambodia during the Vietnam War, carried out sans Congressional consent. Mr. Nixon vetoed the bill, yet it was overridden by Congress and enacted into law as a means for Congress to limit presidential authority to wage war.

In its core provision, the WPA intends "...to fulfill the intent of the framers of the



U.S. President Donald Trump in the Oval Office at the White House in Washington D.C. REUTERS

Constitution...and insure that the collective judgment of both the Congress and the President will apply to the introduction of United States Armed Forces into hostilities."

The U.S. Constitution originally sought to divide war powers between the President and Congress, with Congress alone retaining the authority to declare war and appropriate funding for the military, while recognising the President as the Commander-in-Chief of the armed forces. Yet, even as early as the 1950s and 1960s, through the years of the U.S.'s prolonged military campaigns in the Korean and Vietnam Wars, the lines of responsibility for such engagement began to blur across the executive and legislative branches of the U.S. government.

The Act seeks to remove all room for doubt in this context as it stipulates, first, that even prior to the President committing troops into hostilities on foreign soil, Congress should be consulted "in every possible instance." Second, the WPA requires the President to report to

Congress within 48 hours of deploying U.S. forces, unless Congress itself has declared war or statutorily authorised the action. Third, every U.S. president who commits his military to engage in conflicts abroad must continue reporting to Congress at least every six months for the duration of such an engagement.

As per the Act, if 60 days pass after the President's first reporting deadline to Congress, the use of the U.S. military and its assets is automatically terminated unless Congress had originally declared war or passed legislation authorising the wartime actions. A grace allowed to the president in this regard is that he is permitted to extend the 60-day period by an additional 30 days by certifying in writing to Congress the need for continued use of force.

Options for Trump administration

There are several points of ambiguity regarding Congressional authorisation for war, in this context. Firstly, the precise timeline of reporting requirements to get

the wartime action of the Trump White House sanctioned by Congress is currently a subject of dispute. On one hand there is a lack of clarity on whether the 60-day deadline is April 29 - based on the day that hostilities began - or May 1 - based on the day that the White House informed Congress. Second, a number of Republican lawmakers have said that the ceasefire period should not count toward the 60-day deadline, with a few Democrats supporting this view too. Third, there might be Congressional reticence towards authorising the White House's war efforts, given the lack of recent precedent - Congress has not formally authorised the use of military force since 2002, when the U.S. was involved in hostilities in Iraq.

Nevertheless, the three clear options available to Mr. Trump at this point are the following: to submit to the WPA's authority and seek approval for continued military engagement, to begin winding down the war effort immediately, or to take advantage of the 30-day grace period, and use such an extension to pull back forces and assets from the region, rather than engage in further offensive manoeuvres of any kind.

Mr. Trump might seek to press his own precedent of 2019 when he ignored the deadline set by the WPA to continue military engagement in the conflict in Yemen that also included Saudi Arabia. He might also quote the fact that previous Presidents, from Nixon to Barack Obama - in the context of the war in Libya - did the same and found various excuses to keep fighting abroad without a nod from Congress. In any case, apart from a few scattered efforts by lawmakers such as Republican Lisa Murkowski, who is said to be working on a formal authorisation for the ongoing war so as to introduce guardrails into the operation, yet has not introduced such a proposal to the floor of the Senate, Republicans do not appear to be in a mood to dampen their President's momentum on the war front.

THE GIST

U.S. President Donald Trump's administration launched a military offensive against Iran on February 28. However, the War Powers Act could place the Trump administration's broader war plans under legal and political strain.

Three clear options available to Donald Trump are: to submit to the WPA's authority and seek approval for continued military engagement, to begin winding down the war effort immediately, or to take advantage of the 30-day grace period to pull back forces.

The evolving China-Pakistan space cooperation

The 'all-weather ties' between China and Pakistan are reflected in their space cooperation as well

Gunjan Singh

The Chinese space programme has undertaken major strides since it built and launched its first satellite in 1970. In last half a century Beijing has conducted satellite launches, built its own navigation system, carried out successful spacewalks, and built and operated its own space station. China is also in the process of undertaking a manned moon mission by 2030. China has also consistently promoted its space technologies and pushed for cooperation under Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). This entails "a service network weaved by satellites and ground stations among the BRI partner countries has promoted the space industry to better benefit the local people". China has also used its launching platform, the Long March, to promote its soft power by launching satellite for a number of other countries.

The 'all-weather friendship' between China and Pakistan has been replicated in their space cooperation as well. The partnership began in 1990 with China launching Pakistan's Badr-I satellite. Today, China has built and launched satellites for Pakistan and in 2026 announced that it will send one Pakistani astronaut to the Tiangong space station.

Lunar mission and satellite launches

China has selected Muhammad Zeeshan Ali and Khurram Daud, two Pakistani candidates who will be trained in China for a visit to the Tiangong space station. However, only one of them will be visiting the space station as the payload specialist. This is being done under the 2025 agreement between the China Manned Space Engineering Office (CMSEO) and the Pakistan Space and Upper Atmosphere Research Commission.

China had also launched the ICUBE-Q in 2024 on Chang'e 6 orbiter. This was

developed in a collaboration between the Pakistan's Institute of Space Technology (IST) and Shanghai Jiao Tong University (SJTU). The ICUBE-Q, a lunar CubeSat weighing about 7kg was to explore the far side of the moon. It was successful in capturing images of the moon and the sun and transmitting them back to Earth.

China has been the only country which has launched a number of Pakistani satellites in the last two decades. This has helped Pakistan build a network of reconnaissance and communication satellite network. The latest mission in April 2026 saw Pakistan's indigenous electro-optical satellite, EO-3 being launched from China's Taiyuan Satellite Launch Center. In 2025 China had launched three Pakistani satellites, a remote-sensing satellite (PRSS-2) in October 2025, Pakistan Remote Sensing Satellite (PRSS-1) in July 2025 and PRSC-EO1 in January 2025. In 2024 China had launched the second communication

satellite for Pakistan, PakSat MM1. The first Pakistani communication satellite PAKSAT-IR was launched in 2011.

Navigation cooperation

BeiDou Navigation Satellite System (BDS) is China's indigenous navigation system. It is also seen as the plausible alternative to the United States, Global Positioning System (GPS). The BeiDou system is considered to be very precise with providing information with 2 centimetres precision and this can be improved to 5 millimetres after image processing. This can be very helpful in disaster relief, urban planning, traffic guidance as well as environmental management. In 2014 Pakistan became the first foreign country to use the BeiDou navigation system.

Under the China-Pakistan defence cooperation, the Pakistani military is all equipped to use the BeiDou system. In 2020 Chinese Satellite Navigation Office (CSNO) had announced that they will be establishing a Continuously Operating Radar Station (CORS) network in Pakistan which will be BeiDou enabled.

The developments highlight that the ties between China and Pakistan has moved to the space arena as well, giving Islamabad a strategic advantage. The dual nature of space technology also helps Pakistan gain access to better navigation, telecommunication and disaster relief. (Dr. Gunjan Singh is an Associate Professor at OP Jindal Global University.)

THE GIST

The China-Pakistan space partnership began in 1990 with China launching Pakistan's Badr-I satellite.

China has been the only country which has launched a number of Pakistani satellites in the last two decades. Additionally, under the China-Pakistan defence cooperation, the Pakistani military is all equipped to use the BeiDou navigation system.

